


**Mzuzu University**
**Centre for Open and Distance Learning**

**Module 1**

# Introduction to Library and Study Skills Communication

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**Centre for Open and Distance Learning**

**Module 1**

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## Introduction to Communication Skills

Welcome to *Library and Study Skills*, Communication module 1, coded as ECO1101 offered by the Department of Languages and Literature at Mzuzu University. As a Student registered with this University, you are required to study this course as a compulsory subject regardless of the programme you are pursuing.

Introduction to communication skills aims at equipping you with various techniques for you to learn in the most efficient way using study skills, library skills, listening skills, note-taking skills, reading skills and enables you to cope with the demands of university assessment.

It is envisaged, therefore, that by the end of this course, you will be able to organise as well as manage time, work and resources more efficiently in your academic work; utilise fully library resources including information on the internet, email and On-line Public Access Catalogue (OPAC). You are also expected to learn and improve your reading skills for different purposes.

It should also be born in mind that the objective of this course is also to enable you demonstrate techniques of preparing for and taking examinations. And, in order to adequately meet these objectives, this module is organised and presented in seven units, namely, introduction to human communication; types of human communication; library skills; listening skills; note-taking skills; effective study skills; reading skills and effective examination skills. The first unit is essentially aimed at providing you with the course framework for you to appreciate the need and relevance of the communication skills to your study. For each unit, a recommended reading list is provided to enable you to read more on the subject matter. Please make use of the reading lists to supplement what you read in this module.

You are expected to study this course for a maximum of two semesters. At the beginning of each unit, there is an indication of the number of hours within which you are expected to cover the topic. This is meant to guide you in the management of your time. For each topic, specific activities are provided for self-testing. You are strongly advised to attempt all the activities for effective learning. A sample examination paper is provided at the very end. We hope you will find it useful when preparing for your examination.

The Communication Studies section wishes you all the best as you pursue this very important course. We hope you will find it interesting and useful for your study.

### Visual icons

The following is a list of icons you may find in this module and an explanation of the kind of information they represent.



**Key Words**

This is a list of important new terms and phrases used in the unit. Ensure that you understand their meaning in the context that they are used.



**Learning outcomes**
These are unit objectives. They identify what you are expected to know and understand by the end of the unit. Use them to test your understanding at the end of each unit.



**Activity**
This is a practice activity at the end of each reading text. You have to work out this activity either on the space(s) provided or in a separate notebook. After that, check your response(s) with the answers suggested at the end of each unit.



**Self assessment test**
This is a test at the end of each unit. Work out the answers and compare them with the suggested answers at the end of each unit. Do not turn it in for marking.



**Unit summary**
This is a brief account of the main ideas you have read and learnt in the unit. Make sure you understand the unit very well before you move to the next.



**References**
This is a list of books pertaining to information in the unit. This is a useful guide on choosing appropriate reading materials. Make all possible efforts to supplement information in the unit by additional reading from this list. This will enrich your content of the course.



**Module test**
This is a sample of the end of module examination. Make sure you are familiar with the format of the examination.

# Unit 1 Introduction to Human Communication

## Introduction

This unit is concerned with the content and the process of communication. It concerns all those things that we say, do and feel when we are in the presence of other people. Our intention, in this unit, is to increase your awareness about exchanging meaningful messages with other people. We also aim at showing you the link between communication and classroom activities.

The unit will introduce you to communication in general. In doing so, you are presented with a theoretical framework of communication. Specifically, we define communication; describe the communication process and outline different types of communication. In addition, we emphasise on human communication whose characteristics, classes and advantages have been highlighted. We are confident that upon completing your study you will demonstrate an understanding of all the concepts and new terms used in the unit.

**Areas of emphasis**

- definition of communication
- elements of communication
- code, encoding and decoding
- theories of communication
- characteristics of human communication
- types of human communication



**Key words**

- source
- message
- channel
- verbal communication
- receiver
- message
- channel
- verbal communication
- nonverbal communication
- code
- feedback
- nonverbal symbol
- noise

**Prerequisite knowledge**

Your daily life revolves around communication. You communicate when at home, when teaching and when studying. You experience communication wherever you go and in anything you do. In fact it is almost impossible to have a meaningful life without communication. Your life experiences therefore, will help you understand the contents of this unit.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- define the term communication
- explain functions of elements of various processes in relation to communication theories
- apply elements of communication processes to a classroom situation
- explain the characteristics of human communication
- name two types of human communication
- describe each of the two types of human communication
- explain the advantages and disadvantages of each class of human communication.

**Resources needed**

You may easily understand this unit, if you will have access to the following materials:

- any text book, telephone, radio, fax machine

## 1.1 Definition of communication

**Background information**

For the next few minutes let us go back to what happens in our homes.
Let us have a common starting time, 5 o'clock in the morning. What happened at five? Some of us were fast asleep, others were awake. Let us focus on one imaginary character called Janet.

Janet was fast asleep, her mother knocked at the door. The sound woke her up. She mumbled a few words to herself and opened the door and heard a loud explosion from the main road. The noise drowned her mother's voice. She asked her mother to repeat what she had said and promised to get ready for school in a few minute's time. She got herself ready for another day at school. Having taken her breakfast, she left home walking to school which is 2 kilometres away. On her way to school, she met different people some of whom talked to her. She saw others talking on cell phones, greeting each other and sharing the previous day's experiences.

You may be interested to know that in the above scene, communication has taken place. But what is communication and how crucial is this concept? We will answer these questions shortly.

## 1.2 Definition and elements of communication

### 1.2.1 Definition of communication

Communication is a process of sharing or transferring or exchanging messages (ie information, ideas and feelings) from a source to a receiver through a medium to achieve the desired response.

The definition has included the concept source, receiver, messages, and medium. These are called basic elements or components of any communication process. Beside these, however, you also need to know other concept namely; codes, feedback, encoding, decoding and noise.

### 1.2.2 Source message initiator

People are engaged in the human communication process through two roles. They serve either as source or receiver of a message. A source ***initiates a message*** while a receiver ***is the intended target (destination) of the message.***

### 1.2.3 Roles parts we play

You have to know that individuals do not perform these roles independently. Instead, they are the sources and the receivers of the messages simultaneously and continually. When you engage in a conversation you are both the source (when you speak) and the receiver (when you are talked to).

### 1.2.4 Message

The message is the verbal form of the idea, thought, or feeling that one person (the source) wishes to communicate to another person or group of *people (the receivers).* Simply, the message is the content of the interaction. The message includes the symbols (words and phrases), you use to communicate your ideas, as well as your facial expressions, bodily movements, gestures, touch, tone of voice and other nonverbal codes. The message becomes effective if it is interpreted to meet the intent and purpose and not vice-versa.

### 1.2.5 The channel

The **channel** which is also known as the **medium** *is the means by which a message moves from the source to the receiver of any message.* The message moves from one person to another, by travelling through a channel. Airwaves, sound waves, twisted copper wires, cable are all communication channels. In person-to-person communication, you send messages through a channel of sound waves and light waves that enable receivers to see and hear you.

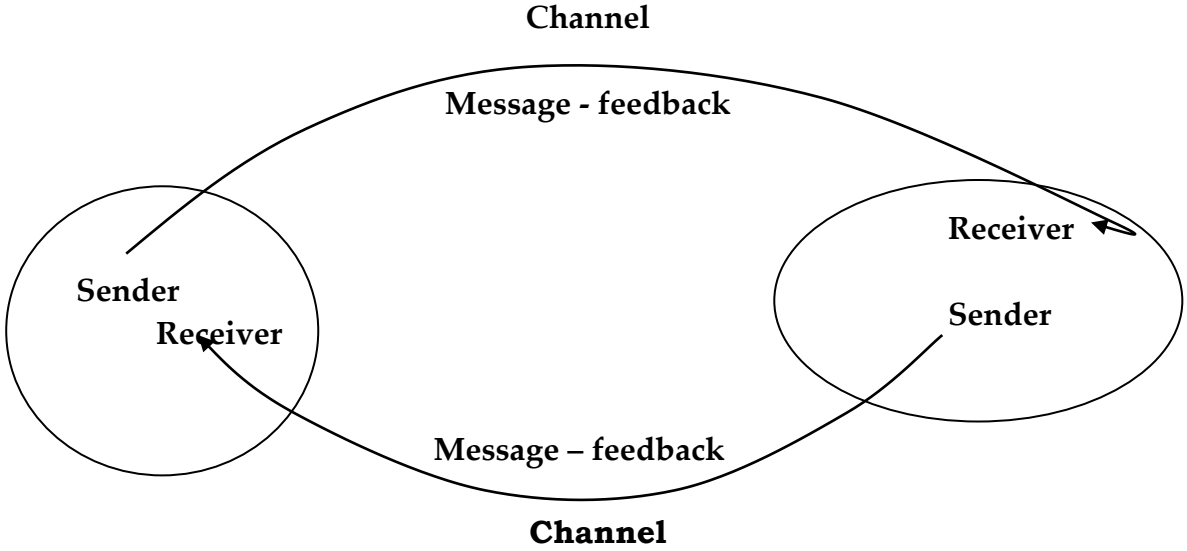
### 1.2.6 Feedback

Feedback refers the receiver's verbal and nonverbal response to the source's message. For instance, when someone tells me a joke I smile. The smile to the message is a form of feedback. And when you make a comment about the weather and I make another one, we are generating more feedback. Ideally, you respond to another person's messages by providing feedback so that the source knows the message was received as intended.

Feedback is any part of communication situation. For example, when you are teaching you may ask a question but nobody answers it. This lack of response or silence is feedback. It

may tell you that either the question was not understood or the learners have not captured anything from the lesson. When they answer your questions and make appropriate comments you get the desired feedback from your lesson.

*Figure 1. Feedback*




*Adapted from Saundra Hybels p.1*

## 1.3 Code, encoding and decoding

### 1.3.1 Code a systematic arrangement of symbols used to create meanings in the mind of another person or persons

The process of communication involves the use of codes. A **code** is a *systematic arrangement of symbols used to create meanings in the mind of another person or persons.* There are **verbal codes** and **nonverbal codes.** Verbal codes consist of *symbols and their grammatical arrangements.* Words are used here. All languages are codes because they use symbols. Nonverbal codes consis*t of symbols that are not words, including bodily movements, your use of space and time, your clothing and other sounds other than words.*

### 1.3.2 Encoding the process of translating an idea or thought into a code.

**Encoding** is *defined as the act of putting an idea or thought into a code.*

### 1.3.3 Decoding the process of assigning meaning to the idea or thought in a code

**Decoding** is *assigning meaning to that idea or thought.* When you are teaching, you send the message to the learners through some symbols which are words. When the learners hear your words they retranslate (interpret) or decode the message into the form that is useful to them. Decoding is done by the receiver's motor skills and senses, ie: thinking, listening, reading etc to assign meaning to the message.

### 1.3.4 Noise

In the communication process, **noise** *is any interference in the encoding and decoding processes that reduces the clarity of a message*. There are two kinds of noise; **physical noise** and

**psychological noise.** **Physical noise** on the other hand keeps the message from being heard. One example is when teaching is interrupted by some learners who are talking loudly, by sound of cars passing by, or a helicopter flying near the classroom. Physical noise could also come from distracting sights such as someone dancing outside the classroom, or from unusual behaviour like someone standing too close for comfort. **Psychological noise** on the other hand, occurs in the minds of the sender-receiver. This kind of noise usually occurs when the sender or receiver is distracted by something happening in their mind. For example when you are teaching, a learner may not understand the lecture because he is thinking about lunch; failure to understand because they are day dreaming about loved ones; if it is an adult learner may be they are thinking about bills. Whatever kind of noise, the bottom line is that noise interferes with receiving, interpreting or providing feedback about a message. You should also know that where there is no feedback communication is incomplete. Incomplete communication results in bad feedback which may in turn breed frustration, boredom etc. **(See Unit 3 on listening barriers)**

 **Activity 1**

Imagine that you got sick consulted a doctor at a hospital

a) Identify the roles that you and the doctor take respectively
b) What messages are arranged during your consultation?

## 1.4 Theories of communication

In the preceding sections, we have examined what communication is, its components and how the components work. In this section, you will learn about theories that have been developed in the study of human communication.

When we talk about theories, we are simply referring to a set of ideas that are meant to explain why things happen the way they do. In most cases these are assumptions.

You must be aware that there are a number of theories that attempt to explain a way people send and receive messages. However, in the interest of time and scope, we will only tackle a few selected ones.

When we look at theories in communication, we look at explanations that give us insight into what happens in the process of exchanging messages from one end to another. Theories are also known as **models** and in this unit; the two terms will be used interchangeably.

As you have already learned in the preceding text, there are many theories that explain the concept of communication process. In this unit we will study:

- The mathematical theory of communication
- The interaction model
- The transaction model

### 1.4.1 The mathematical theory of communication

This theory was developed by Claude Shannon and Warren Weaver in 1949. It asserts that communication is a linear and sequential phenomenon. Here a transmitter sends a signal through a channel. The most important component in this theory is the noise source, which may introduce noise into the channel. The receiver picks up or "collects" the received signal and conducts it to its destination.

The theory encourages us to ask questions about how messages are sent from one end to another. It also enables us to ask "Are there ways to control sources of noise?" "If we can't control sources of noise, are there ways to control the effects of the noise in the receiver?"



**Activity 2**

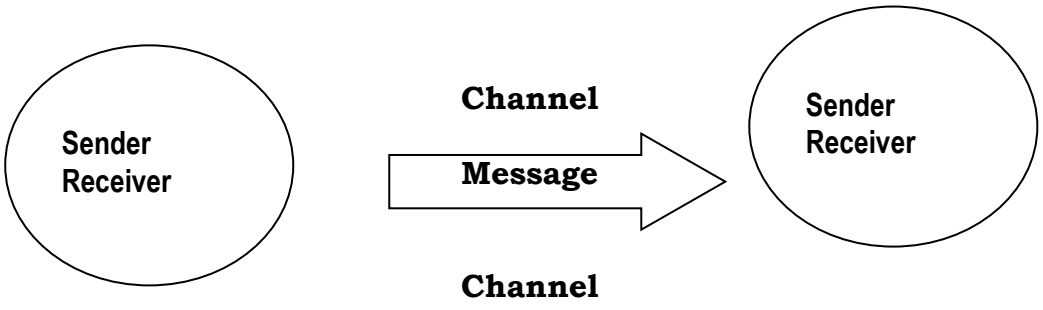
1 Based on the mathematical theory of communication, identify all the components in the classroom setting.
2 What would be the source of noise in the classroom?
3 As a teacher, how would you deal with the problem of noise?
4 What do you think are the weaknesses with the mathematical theory of communication?

### 1.4.2 The interaction model

In this theory, one person sends a message to a second person, who receives it and responds with another message. This model, as shown below, seems to depict a conversation between two people who are interacting and taking turns in sending and receiving messages.

In this theory, it is crucial to note that the receiver cannot return a message until the speaker's message is received.

*Figure 2 The interaction model*

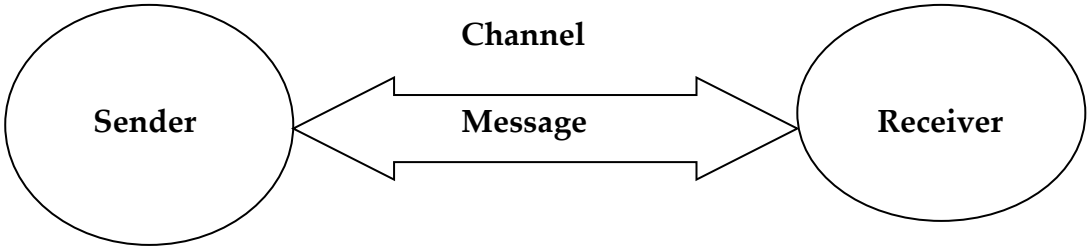



### 1.4.3 The transaction model

This model asserts that communication processes simultaneously send and receive messages. Thus sending and receiving are no longer separate activities, and they do not occur in isolation.

According to the transactional view, people are continually sending and receiving messages; they cannot avoid communication. There is no need to take turns.

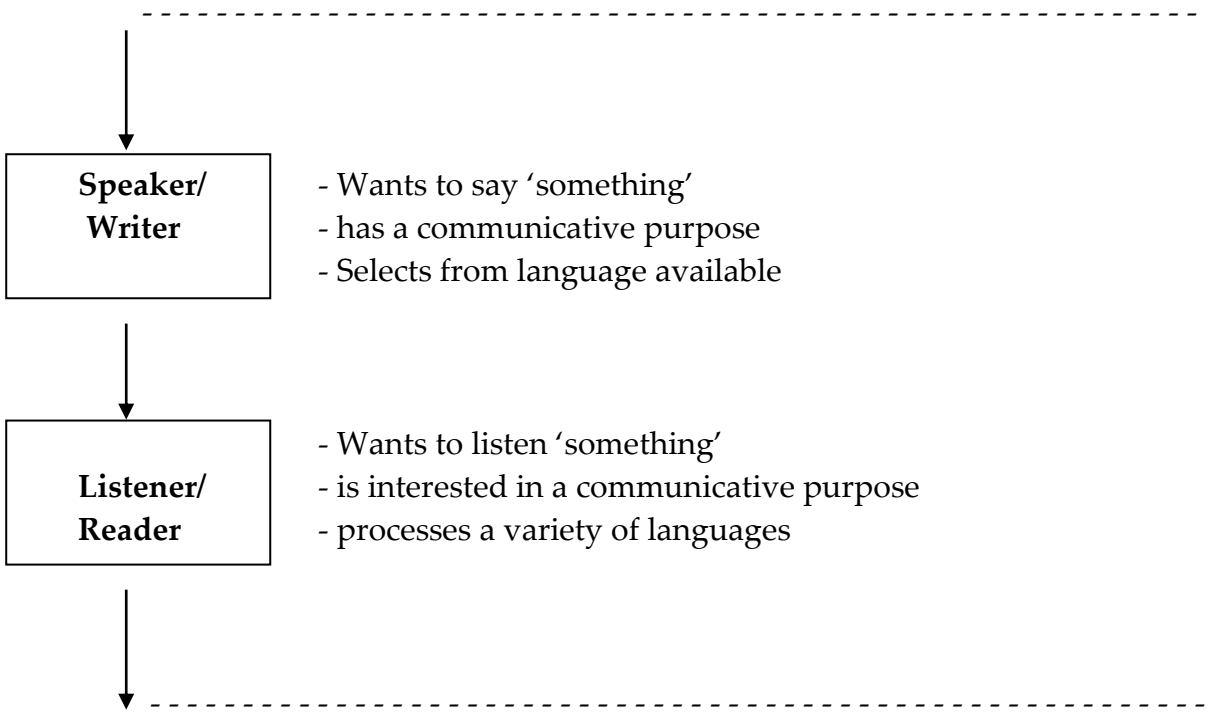
*Figure 3 The transactional theory of communication*




## 1.5 Characteristics of human communication

Having discussed the theories of communication let us now look at the characteristics of human communication. For this to be well understood you must look at the following diagram carefully:

*Figure 4 The nature of communication*






**Activity 3**

By closely looking at figure 1.2, what do you think are the obvious characteristics of human communication?

You may have come up with the following characteristics:

- Whenever communication takes place, there is a speaker and a listener (or a writer and reader) who must interact.
- The speaker has a *purpose* for speaking while the listener is interested in discovering the purpose. The listener may ask; what does this tell us?

- It is possible for communication to have both intentional and unintentional results and effects. For instance, at times, a joke may be interpreted as an insult; a friendly gesture as a love proposal or sexual harassment. On this, you have to know that what we say or do may not always be interpreted in the way we intended. The receiver may understand it in a totally different way than we thought or planned. This is unintentional result of communication.
- Giving each other turns. This is usually common in face-to-face interactions. At least two people who influence each other's actions to some extent are involved. In other words, communication involves both the source and the receiver.
- Communication involves the use of symbols such as movement, gestures and so on, which actually represent the thoughts and feelings of the speaker. To some extent, both the sender and the receiver understand the meanings of these symbols.

## 1.6 Types of human communication

In this section you will learn about two types of human communication which are ***Verbal*** and ***Nonverbal Communications.***

### Verbal communication

This is communication which uses words, i.e. language. Verbal communication can either be ***Oral*** (using voice) or **written.**

### Oral communication

Oral Communication that uses words from the mouth through language

This is the type of communication used in face-to-face interactions, on the phone, radio, TV, at meetings, assemblies or public rallies.

### Advantages

- **Feedback is immediate:** When using oral communication, you can deal with any signs of misunderstanding on the spot. In addition, you can make corrections, amplifications or explanations on the spot.
- **Setting contributes to the way the message will be understood:** Oral messages have an aura of the informal. For instance, in an organisation, an oral reprimand of a colleague or junior may be taken more lightly or more favourably than a written one. In addition, the setting (place) in which such interaction takes place is part of the message for instance in a bar, at a party, in an office etc.
- **Paralanguage** helps in making the message clearer i.e. gestures, body movements, tone of voice and other paralinguistic features such as pitch, tempo, loudness (volume) etc.
- **Problem solving:** Oral communication is ideal for establishing interpersonal relationships and for solving problems or resolving conflicts.

### Disadvantages

- Oral communication is transitory in nature: There is no permanent record that one can refer to at a future date.

- Effectiveness of oral communication heavily depends on the mood of the listener at that particular time. (Impatience, prejudice, anxiety).

**Written communication**

This is the type of communication that uses written materials. Notes, memos, letters, reports, notices, minutes, circulars, general announcements, newsletters and leaflets are some of the common ways of the written communication used in organizations.

**Advantages**

- Written communication provides a permanent record; Ideas expressed in writing achieve the permanency that fixes responsibility. This makes it possible to verify very essential information such as dates, times, figures, names etc. It is because of this that people insist on having written information to confirm oral conversation or messages for authenticity, authority and validity.
- Written communication can reach distant places, far and wide where people may not be reached through oral communication.
- Written communication can be read at the convenience of the recipient. It enables people to read when they are in a more receptive mood or if they are in a different frame of mind they can shelve and read it some other time. If the message is not understood, the message can be read over and over again e.g. written exam over oral exam.
- People tend to remember better what they see in print.
- Written messages are often better structured by their composers. Words and phrases are more carefully chosen than they are in oral communication. Thus, the process of writing forces the composer to think clearly and to present his/her ideas logically. S/he has time to edit and proof- read his work.

* Looking at these advantages you will note that written communication is best for those serious matters which we want to keep a record of e.g. policies, procedures, timetables, technical land statistical information.

**Disadvantages**

Written communication has the following disadvantages:

- We cannot be certain that the message will receive the attention we think it deserves. Executives often have masses of letters, memos etc that vie for their attention therefore there is no guarantee that our messages have been attended as desired.
- Feedback is slow. Therefore it is not good for solving problems.
- There are no nonverbal aids to help the reader get the meaning. The message may not be understood as intended.
- Language errors (e.g. bad grammar, poor construction, spellings and punctuation) may make the message vague or make communication (altogether) impossible.
- There is risk of confidential messages falling into the wrong hands or being received at the wrong time.



**Activity 4**

1 Between written and oral communication, which type do you think would be ideal in resolving conflicts? Explain at least four reasons to justify your choice.
2 In official transactions, which communication would you use
    a) Oral
    b) Written
3 Give two reasons for your choice in (ii) above

### 1.6.2 Non verbal communication

We should not always think of human communication as something that involves spoken words. We also exchange messages using some other mediums. This is where nonverbal communication comes in. ***Nonverbal communication*** refers to interpersonal communication that takes place without use of spoken words or a language. This involves looking at the behaviours of people, other than their use of words, which have socially shared meaning, are intentionally sent or interpreted as intentional, are consciously sent or consciously received, and have the potential feedback from the receiver. What the preceding sentence means is that the nonverbal elements that you use must be known by the receiver and should send the intended messages, achieve appropriate interpretation and generate the desired feedback.

You must know that nonverbal communication can be used independently but sometimes it can be used together with verbal communication in order to fulfil a number of purposes or to complement the words. For example, if you want to emphasise a "**No, No"** you shake your head from side to side. Similarly, you would say, **"Come"** at the same time use your hands to beckon the person you are speaking to. On independence use, an example would be when you shake your head to say no or when you do not say anything but just walk away from someone who has hurt your feelings.

When two people engage in a conversation, they often need continuous evidence that each is attending and responding to the other. This evidence is exhibited by among other things:

**i) Gestures** -these refer to body movements that express an emotion or an idea. For example
- head nodding or shaking to show agreement or disapproval
- touching you ear to show you haven't heard
- putting a finger across the mouth to stop the noise.
- raising a hand in class when you want to ask a question or in a football pitch to denote that someone has committed a foul
- dropping a hand when offering someone a seat

**ii) Eye contact** – the eyes are one of the most reliable indicators of emotions. Even without uttering a single word, people will be able to read messages from our eyes. Eyes tell

whether one is honest or lying. How do you feel when someone you are addressing is looking away? What kind of messages can you get from others' eyes?
In some cultures, it is considered extremely important to look into the eyes of the person we are talking to. If we do not, we are at risk of being considered dishonest or having something to hide. Listeners may also feel that we are not interested in them if our eyes are not focussed on them.

Eye contact is also an important way of gauging audience reaction to your speech. If you are presenting something interesting, the eyes will tell it all and if you confuse the audience, the eyes will equally reveal you.

**iii) Posture-** this is a matter of how we carry our bodies, we walk, sit and stand. It can give the audience all sorts of messages. For instance, if you drag your feet or slouch, you could be communicating that you are lazy, sick, tired, or depressed – none of which you would want to communicate when giving a speech.

**iv) Pictures-** pictures are very helpful in communication. They are attractive to the eye, they also communicate in an instant and comprehensive manner to the illiterate. For example, if you went to a foreign land whose language you do not understand it would be easier for you to trace a toilet basically by looking at the pictures of man and woman on the door posts.

**Advantages of pictorial communication**
Pictorial communication is paramount in that pictures are:

- international
- instantaneous in their impact
- comprehensible to the illiterate
- easily remembered

**Disadvantages of communication through pictures**
Much as there are a number of advantages with pictures, you need to be aware that they have some disadvantages. They cannot be used for such materials as:

- Reasoned arguments
- Detailed instructions
- Exact information
- Definition
- Records of discussions
- Legal matters etc

**v) Dressing and grooming**
Dressing is also another non verbal way of transmitting messages. The way one dresses tells a story. It is important to dress to suit the occasion. Clothes and decorations on the body, like body language, send messages about ourselves to all we meet. At times, we dress to indicate the kind of person we wish to play in life.

**vi) Use of space**

We also communicate by the way we use our space. People use space differently and it may govern personal actions and behaviour of others. A good illustration of this is standing or sitting close to someone or moving away from someone love and hatred respectively. Intimate relationships tend to be very close to each other.

**vii) Facial expression**

This refers to any nonverbal cue expressed by the speakers face. We can get more messages merely by observing, analysing and interpreting expressions being made on people's faces. For example, when someone smiles he or she may communicate to us that they are happy and if they frown, they may denote anger or sadness.



**Activity 6**

1 Think of any two road signs you have come across and state what they mean.
2 Why is it difficult to judge people based on their dressing and grooming? Cite four examples to illustrate your arguments.



**Self-assessment test**

1 In your own words, explain briefly what is meant by the following:
   a) source
   b) receiver
   c) message
   d) channel
   e) medium
2 Why is feedback considered crucial in the communication process?
   Using relevant examples clearly compare and contrast oral and written communication.
3 a) Define a theory
   b) Using the mathematical theory of communication describe the communication process in a classroom setting.



**Unit summary**

In this unit, we have looked at how messages are transmitted from one end to another. It has been observed that the communication process is complex and that it needs a coordination of several elements in order to bring about desired fruits. We have also discussed how some people have tried to unravel the mystery behind communication by means of theories. More importantly, two types of communication have been tackled. As you have noted both types work independently but on a greater extent they complement each other. It is our hope that you will be able to employ all the concepts and terms used in the unit to foster your communication, not only as a teacher but in other instances as well



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# Unit 2 Library Skills

## Introduction

This unit introduces you to the necessary skills to enable you make full use of the library. Our main concern is on types of libraries, arrangement of materials and information technology in the library.

**Areas of emphasis**

- library
- definition of library
- function of library
- types of libraries
- sections of a library
- information arrangement
- classification
- call numbers
- catalogue and its types



**Key words**

- library, reserve collection, reference books, catalogue, periodicals,
- journals, input device, dewey classification system,
- library of congress, hardware, internet, e-mail

**Prerequisite knowledge**

As a student, you have undoubtedly been to the library. It is obvious that your ability to perform well is to a larger extent dependent on the effective use of the library. A library exposes you to a range of facilities like books, periodicals, journals, newspapers and many more which will help you fully appreciate this unit.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit you should be able to:

- define the term library
- mention functions of the library
- identify various sections of the library
- use different section of the library effectively
- distinguish types of libraries and their use
- locate materials relevant to your needs using different classification system
- describe components of a computer
- relay and download information using the internet
- relay and download information using the internet.

**Other resources needed**

- computer
- disks (floppy or flush)
- digital camera
- photocopier
- scanner

## 2.1 The library

**Background Information**

The library involves collection of information resources in print or in other forms that is organised and made accessible for reading or studying. The word derives from the Latin **liber** which means 'book'. The origin of libraries lies in the keeping of written records, a practice that dates at least to the 3rd millennium BC in Babylonia. The first libraries as repositories of books were those of the Greek temples and those established in conjunction with the Greek schools of philosophy in the 4th Century BC. Today's libraries frequently contain periodicals, microfilms, tapes, videos, compact discs, and other materials in addition to books. The growth of on-line communication networks has enabled library users to search electronically linked databases worldwide. Traditionally, university students all over the world have had to make use of the library in the course of their studies including research works. You will equally find the library helpful as you pursue your studies.

## 2.2 Definition of library

**Library room where books and other reading materials are kept**

The *Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary of Current English defines* a library as a building in which collections of books, CDs, newspapers, etc are kept for people to read study or borrow. A library has also been defined as follows:

- a room where books are kept.
- a collection of literary documents or records kept for reference or borrowing.
- a depository built to contain books and other materials for reading and study.
- a building that houses a collection of books and other materials.

In its traditional sense, a library is a collection of books and periodicals. It can refer to an individual's private collection, but more often it is a large collection.



**Activity 1**

1 In your own words define the term library.
2 Mention any four resources found in the library.

## 2.3 Functions of a library

A library is very important in your life as a student. It serves the following functions:

- to store information of academic value.

- to provide conducive environment for studying.
- to provide convenient access to diverse sources of information such as electronic and printed materials.
- to facilitate provision of source materials for research project.

## 2.4 Types of libraries

Libraries are categorised into different types generally based on their core functions and readership target. They can be divided into categories by several methods:

**2.4.1** By the entity (institution, municipality or corporate body) that supports or operates it. Examples include:

- school libraries
- private libraries
- corporate libraries
- government libraries
- academic libraries
- historical society libraries

**2.4.2** By the type of documents or materials it holds. Examples are:

- architecture libraries
- fine arts libraries
- law libraries
- medical libraries
- military libraries
- theological libraries

**2.4.3** By the users it serves, for example military communities

**2.4.3** By traditional professional divisions. Here we have the following examples:

- **Academic libraries**. These are libraries located on the campuses of colleges and universities and serve primarily the students and faculty of that and other academic University Library.
- **School libraries**. Most public and private primary and secondary schools have libraries designed to support the curriculum. For example, we have Luwinga Secondary School Library in the city of Mzuzu.
- **Public libraries** or public lending libraries.

These libraries provide services to the general public and make at least some of their books available for borrowing, so that readers may use them at home over a period of days or weeks. Many public libraries also serve as community organizations that provide free services and events to the public. For example, the National Library in Malawi.

- **Special libraries.** All other libraries fall into this category. Many private businesses and public organisations, including hospitals, museums, research laboratories, law firms and many government departments and agencies, maintain their own libraries for the use of their employees in conducting specialised research related to their work. Special

libraries may or may not be accessible to some identified part of the general public. An example here is any organisational Library.



**Activity 2**

1 As a student you must have made use of the library, state reasons why you went to the library.
2 Categorise at least four libraries found in Malawi in line with the types that you have learnt.

## 2.5 Sections of the library

It is important to note that any library is organised in terms of sections to facilitate easy storage and access of information. For instance, the library at Mzuzu University is divided into the following sections:

### 2.5.1 Virtual or electronic section

This is a section where computers are installed. There are two rooms where Internet can be accessed, namely, the Internet room and American corner.

### 2.5.2 Main library section – open shelves

This is where you find books that are in general circulation. Readers are allowed to borrow books from this section for some days or weeks. Normally no advance bookings are required because the books are fairly adequate.

### 2.5.3 Reprographic section

This section offers photocopying and binding services.

### 2.5.4 Malawiana section

This is a section where works / materials such as books, journals, newspapers, past papers, dissertations, newsletters produced by different Malawian writers are stored. Books are normally not taken out (they are accessed and read within the library) unless permission has dully been sought from the Librarian.

### 2.5.5 Reserve collection / short loan section

This contains particularly relevant and high demand books in short supply. The books are normally read within the library and can be taken out at the close of the library to be returned early in the morning. Readers are normally given a two-hour period to access a book. Any violation of this rule attracts a penalty which is prescribed by the librarian. Usually, lecturers from time to time can place on reserve materials they regard important and in short supply in their courses for students to access. In this section books are arranged alphabetically.

### 2.5.6 Reference section

This is a section which contains books that have facts and information which you look at when you want to find out something in particular. For example, this section keeps

encyclopaedia, dictionaries and thesaurus. You also use this section when you have a need for a short factual answer to a question.

## 2.6 Arrangement of information in the library

### 2.6.1 Classification process of gathering similar things together

Arrangement of materials in the library is also known as library classification. Library classification is the systematic arrangement by subject of books and other material on shelves or of catalogue and index entries in the manner which is most useful to those who read or who seek a definite piece of information.

This classification is intended to achieve the following:

- It makes it possible for information on a subject to be retrieved without having to search the whole library stock.
- It gives us an overview of the subject field covered.
- It groups together the topics that the users of the collection want it grouped together.
- The materials are grouped in a logical order which link the items available in the shelves to the library catalogue.

### 2.6.2 Types of classification

There are a variety of classification systems or schemes. Different libraries have freedom to choose which classification system to subscribe to. In most libraries including Mzuzu University library two main types are used. These are:

a) Dewey decimal classification (DDC).
b) Library of congress classification.

#### i) Dewey decimal classification system (DDC)

The system was developed by Melvil Dewey in 1876. It was conceived as a classification of knowledge for the purpose of organising the library. It divides knowledge into nine main disciplinary classes (such as class 100 – philosophy, class 300 – social sciences, class 600 – technology) and one class for general works.

The main ten classes according to Dewey decimal classification system are:

| | |
|---|---|
| 001 - 099 | generalities |
| 100 - 199 | philosophy |
| 200 - 299 | religion |
| 300 - 399 | social Sciences |
| 400 - 499 | language |
| 500 - 599 | pure Sciences |
| 600 - 699 | technology |
| 700 - 799 | the arts |
| 800 - 899 | literature |
| 900 - 999 | geography and history |

The main feature of Dewey decimal classification is that it uses numbers and decimals. You should usually remember that each main class of DDC has ten divisions; each division has ten subdivisions and so on. If a library uses this classification it means that users will be able to retrieve information in different fields by using the numbers as guiding factor on the shelves.

ii) **The library of congress classification**

This system was developed years after DDC. It uses alphabetical letters instead of numbers.

It classifies materials based on their disciplines and it was developed to accommodate all subject areas represented in library collection corresponding to major academic areas or disciplines. The general works at the beginning of shelves belong to class A and class Z is found at the end which constitutes the bibliography and library science class. The greater part of the alphabetical notation is allocated to the humanities and the social sciences (classes B to P), with classes Q to V provided for science and technology. As a matter of exemplifying, L belongs to materials on education therefore different materials containing education information may be labelled LA or LB. So when you are interested in education books you can go to the shelves and check where L is. You will find education books there.

## 2.7 Understanding call numbers

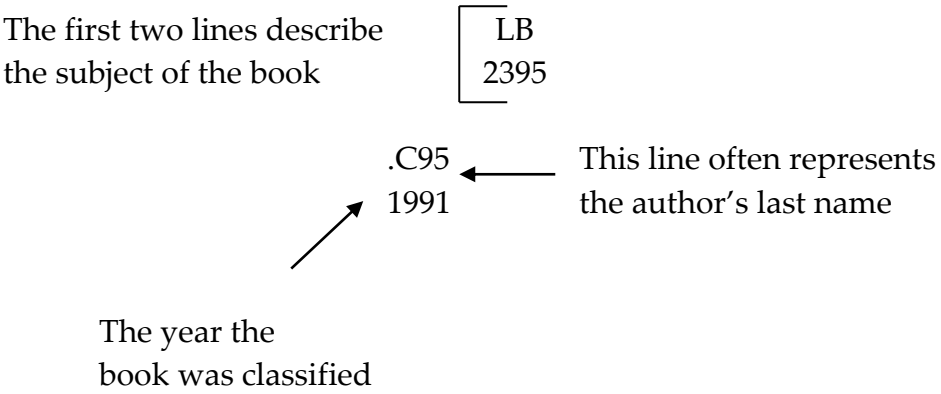
Have you ever wondered how library books are assigned their places on the shelves? Did you know that the call number / classification mark – the number placed on the spine of the book is a code which provides valuable information about the book? This section will try to make you understand and use call numbers effectively.

### 2.7.1 What are call numbers for?

Each book in the library has a unique number called *call number*. A call number also known as a classification mark is like an address: it tells us where the book is located in the library. Call numbers appear from top to bottom on the spines of books and from left to right in the online catalogue.

### 2.7.2 What does the call number mean?

The first sections of the call number represent the subject of the book. The letter-and-decimal section of the call number often represents the author's last name and the last section of a call number is often the date of publication. This can be illustrated as follows:




### 2.8 Location prefixes

When a call number looks like the example above (LB2395. C95 1991) the book is shelved on the open shelves of the Library.

Example:

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ref | AG243 | .G87 | 1992 |

The ref prefix indicates that this book is shelved in the reference collection section.
Location prefixes means that a book is shelved in a special place and may have loan restrictions.

Mzuzu University Library uses the following location prefixes:

| Prefix | Collection | Loan period | Library location |
|---|---|---|---|
| Blank | Circulation | 30 days | Open shelf |
| MAL | Malawiana | Not to be taken out of the library | Malawiana Section |
| Ref | References Collection | | 1st floor |
| Reserve | Reserve book set aside for a class inside the library | 2 hours/ time | Circulation Counter |
| | | | |

## Prefix collection Mzuzu University loan period library location

### 2.9 Library catalogue

**Catalogue list of books and other material housed in a library and arranged in recognised order**

Having talked about call numbers you also need to know about the library catalogue. A catalogue refers to a complete list of all materials found in the library. This is a product of classification system and it basically displays only those materials that are being stocked in the library.

#### 2.9.1 Forms of catalogue

When you visit libraries you will mostly meet two forms of catalogue. These are:

- card catalogue
- electronic catalogue.

**a) Card catalogue**

This is a traditional form of cataloguing in which cards are used to display materials found / stocked in the library.

The card entries are arranged alphabetically either by author names or subjects (book titles). Card entries are filed in drawers, housed in cabinets. When a reader wants to get a particular book they check the entries, these entries guide them to the shelves and they can easily retrieve any book of their choice.

**b) Electronic catalogue**

This one uses computers and is therefore also known as computer catalogue. It is faster as compared to the card catalogue which is manual. This computerised catalogue system at Mzuzu University is known as online public access catalogue (OPAC).

In this, users can retrieve catalogue records directly from a computer data base. The mode of display is through a computer terminal where after a library user has entered his/her request information is displayed instantly on a monitor. When you want to use electronic catalogue, you can either punch in the author name or title of a particular book you want to use. Immediately feedback will be given. If the book is available, you will be guided to the shelf where you can retrieve it and if it is not available, you will instantly be told so.



**Activity 3**

1 Name two types of classification schemes.
2 What are the major differences between those two types?

## 2.10 The library and information technology

This section basically introduces you to the world of computers – how computers are utilised in the storage, sending and receiving of messages/information.

### 2.10.1 Components of a computer

A computer has two essential components namely: Hardware and Software.
You need to fully appreciate these components. You need to enjoy your usage of components. By hardware we refer to a computer component which is inbuilt and has the potential to be loaded with software and can be operated independently. On the other hand, software refers to programmes which are loaded onto a computer to facilitate specific operations such as Microsoft Word for word processing and Microsoft Excel for spread sheets and Power Point for pictorial presentations.

### 2.10.1 Input devices

In order to operate a computer, you need to make use of some input devices.

An input device lets you communicate with a computer. You can use input devices to enter information and issue commands. A keyboard, a mouse, a scanner, a digital camera, a touch pad and joystick are examples of input devices. Some common computer input devices:

**Keyboard**

The keyboard has the following functions and characteristics:



- used to type data into the computer
- most common input device today
- has special keys for giving the computer commands
- commands tell the computer to do something, like save the file or delete the file
- these special keys are called command or function keys

**Pointing devices**

- Pointing devices move some object on the screen and can do some action
- Common pointing devices include:

| | |
|---|---|
|  | ○ Mouse - most common pointing device |
|  | ○ Track ball – This is basically an up and down scroller. Located onto the mouse |
|  | Joystick |
|  | ○ Game controller |

**Scanner**



A scanner allows you to scan documents, pictures, or graphics and view them on the computer. You can also use software to edit the items you scan The commonest software to edit graphics include: Photoshop and In-design adobe Quack express..

- Used to put printed pictures and text into a computer
- Converts an image into dots that the computer can understand
- To scan text, optical character recognition (OCR) software is needed

**Digital camera**

- A digital camera is used to take electronic pictures of an object
- The pictures taken by a digital camera can be used directly by a computer



**Microphone**



- A microphone is used to put sound into a computer
- It needs sound recording software

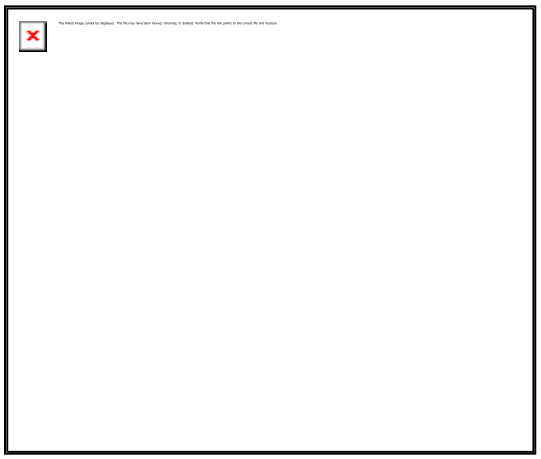
**CD-ROM/DVD-ROM**



- It can be used to record both sound and images into a computer
- Use a laser to read a Compact Disk (CD) or a DVD disk
- Can read data, music or audio and picture (VCD/DVD) compact discs.

**Video capture card**

- It is usually placed inside the computer's case
- It is used for capturing video into a computer
- It needs video source such as video camera or video recorder






**Internet as a source of information in the library**

Apart from books and other printed materials, you can also access some information from the internet. The internet is the most modern, efficient and convenient means of obtaining up-to-date information. By definition, the internet means an international computer network connecting other networks and computers from companies, universities etc. It is an information / communication system of millions of computers that are connected together.

The internet is a very important facility in the library. To deny that the internet has had a major impact on libraries' reference services to their patrons, would be equivalent to denying the fact hat the sun rises in the east and sets in the west.

The internet has the following advantages:

- It provides more up-to-date information.
- Information can be found more quickly.
- It allows people to send and receive electronic messages (e-mails).
- It allows one to access information at their convenience.

If you have never used the internet or have never seen how it works, you need not to worry because during your orientation at Mzuzu University as well as some other selected places, you will be taught how to use this facility.



**Activity 4**

1 Imagine that you have been given an assignment to write an essay on the impact of HIV and AIDS on the Malawian economy. Explain how you can use the electronic catalogue to find relevant information for the topics.

2 In your own words, based on what you have learnt, explain how materials are arranged in the library.

3 In your own words, write brief notes on the following devices:
   a) Monitor
   b) Keyboard
   c) Mouse
   d) Internet
   e) Hardware
   f) Software



**Self assessment test**

1 Libraries have been classified into different categories, in which category does Mzuzu University library and learning resource centre fit?
2 a) Briefly, describe a computer.
   b) How can a computer assist you in your studies?
3 It is commonly said that a computer is not as intelligent as a human being. Discuss.
4 a) Define the term library catalogue.
   b) Why is it important for a student to make use of a library catalogue?
5 Why are libraries considered ideal places for studying?



**Summary**

This unit has provided you with an orientation on the importance and use of the library efficiently, how information is arranged in the library and how the internet assists in searching for information and sending electronic mails (e-mails). This unit has also introduced you to the world of computers where an attempt has been made to describe how important components of a computer work. We believe that the information we have provided in this unit will help you to develop skills that are necessary for efficient utilisation of the library.



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# Unit 3 Listening Skills

## Introduction

This unit introduces you to listening as a necessary skill that complements speaking. You will thus be introduced to the theory of listening; the process of listening; and familiarise yourself with various examples of effective listening.

**Areas of emphasis**

- listening as an active process
- listening process
- types of listening
- listening for information
- overcoming barriers to effective listening
- cultural barriers to effective listening



**Key words**

- attitude, critical listening, active listening, hearing, listening,
- precision, retention, selective listening, awareness, reception,
- perception

**Prerequisite knowledge**

Listening skills can be learned. Good listeners are effective communicators. A communication transaction depends on effective listening as much as it does on speaking. Good listening skills can be learned and further developed. It is important to note that listening takes the largest share of all our communicative activities. This is true of our every day life but also at working places including schools. In fact, studies have shown that the personal failures and successes that we experience are partially attributed to our listening skills.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- state the theory of listening
- compare and contrast listening with hearing
- explain key components of the listening process
- identify specific levels or kinds of listening
- explain strategies that can enhance listening
- identify barriers to effective listening and how to overcome them
- participate actively in class discussions.

**Other resources**

- radio or television set to assist you in deciphering different types of listening

## 3.1 Background information

**Listening is an active process**

Listening is an intentional act just as speaking is. When someone is speaking to us we know that their intention is to communicate. Likewise, when someone is listening, we know that the intention is to actively participate in the communication process. It is therefore, important to be good listeners by developing specific skills and attitudes.

First, we must distinguish *listening* from *hearing*. **Hearing** is defined as a *sense* that allows you to perceive sound. It is a physical act that requires only the reception of sound waves. Since hearing is passive, you often hear even when you don't want to. It implies no intention from the "receiver" of the communication.

We define **Listening** as a mental process that requires concentrating on sound, deriving meaning from it and reacting to it. In contrast, listening is an active process. It begins with hearing but it goes beyond the use of one of the senses. **Listening** is an intentional act. It thus requires some effort and concentration. In other words, it is a process of receiving, attending to and assigning meaning to aural stimuli. In the absence of listening, the communication process itself becomes ineffective.

In any community, people spend most of their time listening compared to other communicative activities. The same situation prevails at work places as well as in academic institutions. For communication to occur, listening must take place. In fact feedback is, primarily, triggered by listening.

When we talk to each other, we process both verbal and nonverbal messages. We receive many messages and, we attend to some of them and assign a variety of meanings to those messages. We are listeners during most of the times that we are awake.

### 3.1.1 Case study

**Consider the following case study:**

*Mabvuto has just emerged from seeing his aunt in a female ward at Mzuzu Central Hospital. He meets his uncle Malenga in the corridor also heading towards the same ward. They greet in silence by shaking hands and then:*

Malenga: How is the patient this morning? *(He asks almost in a whisper)*

Mabvuto: *(He throws his arms sideways showing despair)*
Uncle, we only have to pray to God. She is still not able to eat.

Malenga: Were you able to speak to her? Could she recognize you? Has she stopped vomiting and what about the glucose drip. How many bottles of glucose so far? *(He looks into Mabvuto's eyes in desperation)*

Mabvuto: There is a slight improvement from yesterday. At least her face brightened up a bit though she is not yet able to speak. Please uncle, you will see for yourself.

Malenga: (He holds his nephew's hand firmly) Don't worry she will be fine soon. (He then moves away in the opposite direction) I will call you in the afternoon. (Mabvuto simply waves his hand and continues walking slowly)

Note how Mabvuto and Malenga are able to listen to each other without relying on spoken language. For instance to the question: *How is the patient?* Malenga does not receive a direct answer but he has a complete understanding of the response in both verbal and non-verbal forms. The feedback from each one of them directs the course of their communication. Such that when Mabvuto says "Please uncle, you will see for yourself" Malenga realises that his nephew prefers not to continue talking. He therefore offers reassurance by a firm hold of his hand accompanied comforting words. In fact immediately after that gesture, he starts moving away. All this conversation is sustained mainly by listening to each other. In fact it is a process that moves from one stage to the other.

### 3.2 The listening process

Since listening is a process, a number of activities take place for it to have taken place. For the purpose of clarity, such events are usually divided into three stages as follows:

**Stage 1: Awareness reception**

This is a stage of hearing. Before Mabvuto can begin listening, he becomes aware of Malenga's need to communicate. In fact this is initially triggered by the silent handshake. Awareness at this stage is established which translates into the need to listen.
From then on each of them becomes attentive to what is being said. In other words, reception of the message through the senses of hearing (verbal signals - words) and sight (non-verbal signals) takes place.

**Stage 2: Perception**

At this stage, both speakers are able to interpret what is being said thereby deriving meaning from the words. This is the stage of perception or understanding. Perception can only be attained once the attentive listener gets the message and the brain interprets what has reached it through the senses.

**Stage 3: Judgment**

Note that immediately after Malenga has spoken, he first makes a contextual judgment of the message. They both possess sufficient background knowledge about the condition of the patient. They are both concerned and this explains the non- explicit verbal response

whose message becomes explicit due to the context as well as the gesture accompanying it. Consequently, this stage allows for feedback, advice, action and reaction. Listening at this stage turns into a two-way process, a conversation.
Remember that the three stages outlined above apply generally to all situations of communication with variations in terms of the intensity for each stage depending on the reasons for listening. This happens because there are different reasons for listening.



**Activity 1**

Turn back to 3.7.1 and study again the conversation between Malenga and Mabvuto. Observe all the non-verbal forms of communication indicated in the text. Against each non-verbal form provide the most appropriate meaning to it and explain the link with the adjacent verbal communication (either before or after the non-verbal form)

## 3.3 Types of listening

### 3.3.1 Listening is influenced by contexts

Is it possible to listen in the same manner be it in class or at a church service; at a market place whilst shopping or at a corporate management meeting; at a political public rally or at a funeral ceremony; whilst chatting with a friend or indeed discussing the condition of a patient with a relative in a hospital corridor. It is important to appreciate that since listening takes concentration and effort, the tendency is to reserve our most demanding listening skills for special occasions. We can thus categorise listening as follows:

### 3.3.2 Pleasure and enjoyment

Listening for pleasure takes place when we listen to music, TV, or radio as a pass time activity. It does not require much concentration. In fact in the case of music, we rarely listen to every word, phrase or sentence. Some words easily pass without getting noticed. They are seldom meant to be remembered or recorded. A similar situation applies to talk shows. The only difference here is that one has to listen to the flow of the talk by being part of the communication otherwise you run the risk of losing out on the entertainment or amusement. The common feature of all such situations is that listening for enjoyment requires very little involvement with the text.

### 3.3.3 Listening for information

This type of listening requires more concentration than listening for enjoyment. A simple example here is when you listen to a class discussion or to an informative speech. As a student, you frequently need to apply this type of listening mainly in preparation for examinations or tests. The general objective is to be able to store or recall the information for future use. It is similar to listening to instructions on how to get to Mzimba from Lilongwe for example. Retention of such information becomes necessary for one to reach the destination. A similar example is listening to a training session. Contrast this with listening to an explanation of how your friend escaped a near fatal car accident.

### 1.3.4 Critical listening

Critical listening is more than just listening for information. It involves analysing and evaluating information. When a police constable is investigating a crime case by interrogating a suspect, he goes beyond mere listening with the purpose of recording or recalling the information. He aims at discovering more than what is said by the suspect. Depending on the subject at hand, a researcher may also do the same when collecting information for a study. Some students apply this type of listening from time to time, especially when listening to instructions and explanation on how to conduct a scientific experiment in a laboratory.

### 3.3.5 Precision listening

When we are involved in listening to details for clues to the speaker's feelings or state of mind, we go beyond critical listening. The objective here is not to get the facts but also the subtle messages and feelings conveyed through the quality of voice or facial expression. This is called listening with precision or exactness with the ability to distinguish clearly. What matters in such cases is not only what is said but also how it is said. To a precision listener, both the substance and the style are important.

### 3.3.6 Empathic listening

This is the most advanced type of listening. It needs concentration, retention and judgment. It also requires "the ability to put yourself in someone else's place and understand his or her feelings." This is called empathy, which requires the skills of a precision listener motivated to listen for an understanding of how the speaker feels.

Qualities of an empathic listener are as follows:

- He/she does not rush to offer a personal opinion
- Is capable of withstanding emotions that are difficult to talk about
- Is capable of suspending judgment and ready to offer opinions when asked
- Understands and recognises the choice for others to talk and respects the role of a listener
- Respects the feelings of others without necessarily agreeing with those feelings.

Consider the situation when Mabvuto in case study 3.1.1 saying "Please uncle, you will see for yourself." Malenga immediately realizes that his nephew is distressed and does not feel like continuing talking about the patient. He thus holds and presses his hand by way of reassuring him. Simultaneously, he utters words of encouragement and starts to move in the opposite direction. Malenga's actions including what he says amount to a demonstration of empathic listening towards his nephew. He is, therefore, able to understand and share Mabvuto's feelings.

**A summary of types of listening**

| | **Definition** | **Motive** | **Skill required** | **Application example** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Listening for** | Entertainment | Listening | None | Listening to a |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Enjoyment** | | passively for ones own pleasure | | television comedy |
| **Listening for information** | Gathering facts, opinions and other information | Listening to acquire data for recall | Concentration, may require note-taking skills, retention | Listening to a sales presentation, Listening to a training session |
| **Critical Listening** | Listening with the intent to judge or evaluate | Listening to make an evaluation or judgment of what is said or based on what is said | Concentration, may require note-taking skills, retention, analysis, reflection | Interviewing a potential employee |
| **Precision listening** | Understanding substance and style for clues as to meaning | Listening with attention to details that give you clues to the speaker's emotion or state of mind | Concentration, may require note-taking skills, retention, analysis, reflection, recall of details, Willingness to evaluate how something is said as well as what is said | Listening to a student making a research study presentation, listening to a colleague rehearse a speech with the intent of giving advice |
| **Empathic listening** | Listening to help others | Listening to understand another person's emotions and state of mind | Concentration, retention, reflection empathy, suspension of judgment | Listening to various sides of a conflict express themselves |

### 3.4 Overcoming barriers to effective listening

A listening barrier is any physical, mental or cultural condition that reduces the likelihood of a message to be received and understood as intended. When this happens, interference of effective communication takes place. Once listening barriers are reduced, communication becomes more efficient and effective. It is, therefore, important to understand listening barriers in order to avoid them.

Barriers to effective listening include: physical barriers, mental barriers, attitudes and cultural barriers. We will discuss these barriers in detail by examining specific situations.

### 3.4.1 Physical barriers to listening

Physical barriers to listen constitute anything that interferes with the hearing. Listening cannot take place where there is loss of hearing, be it partial or total. A poor audio system can also cause a physical barrier to listening. It is important to note that both listeners and speakers share responsibility for good listening by avoiding such barriers.

### 3.4.2 Mental barriers to listening

A wandering mind or inattention that results into lack of concentration represents the most common mental barrier. Thus mental barriers to listening are more difficult to deal with. Such barriers make our minds wander when we are listening.

It has been proved that most speakers communicate at 125-250 words per minute against our brains that process words at over 500 words per minute. The gap between the two tends to be filled by empathy, judgment, analysis and the other skills that help us to listen. This is especially so when we listen for information, criticism, precision and empathy.

### 3.4.3 Listener's attitudes

**Attitudes in listening**

Attitudes refer to beliefs or feelings we have about ourselves, other people, ideas and events. In other words, it is a state of mind about something or someone. Naturally, an audience with a hostile or apathetic attitude is most likely to experience listening problems. A good example is in a class where students have a negative attitude about a topic, subject or tutor; listening is likely to be negatively affected.

Selective listening sometimes also stems from an attitude problem of blocking out anything we do not want to hear and pay attention to information that coincides with our beliefs. This also can result to a barrier to listening.

Sometimes a listener's personal attitude makes him jump to conclusions before the speaker has concluded what he has to say. Sometimes we think we know what another person will or is about to say and we interrupt or jump to a conclusion. We assume we know the other person's intention based on how we felt. Hence the cliché "I know what you are going to say." Most of the times our guess is wrong! The way to deal with this problem is to learn to be patient. We must learn to listen to the entire message before responding. Such patience is known as "holding fire" and allows us to base our conclusion on all of the information instead of part of it.

### 3.4.4 Cultural barriers to listening

**Cultural barriers in language, (accent, dialect)**

Cultural barriers readily manifest in language, dialect or accent differences. It is thus important to be sensitive to such differences to be able to listen effectively. The obligation to overcome such barriers rests with the speaker as well. Native speakers of English, for instance, find it difficult to listen to non- native speakers due to accents. It requires more concentration to listen to overall content rather than trying to understand each specific word that is said.

Even within the same linguistic community, the use of certain words in English is considered rude by those in other cultures. For instance, to some cultures "hey" is a greeting similar to "hi" or "hello."

To some English speakers, "hey" is a means of getting someone's attention in a rude way. Hence using the word "hey" can be a barrier to listening if it is interpreted as rudeness rather than a friendly greeting.

 **Activity 2**

Study the following table presenting common listening barriers. For each type of a barrier an example is provided. Provide at least two solutions to avoid each of the barriers be it caused by the speaker or listener.

| **Barrier** | **Explanation/example** | **Solutions to overcome barrier** |
|---|---|---|
| Competing noises | Our hearing can be obscured by noise such as shuffling feet in a class, clashing cafeteria trays, other conversations | |
| Blocked view | Someone could sit between the speaker and listener. The sitting arrangement might not allow easy viewing of the speaker | |
| Poor speaking volume | A speaker who doesn't "speak up" creates a barrier for listeners | |
| Listener's physical condition | We sometimes try to listen when we are tired or ill. | |
| Listener's attitude | Sometimes a listener is not prepared to listen to someone. The listener can be bored or prejudiced, perhaps even hostile. The listener might even be listening selectively; that is, the listener might be listening only things he or she wants to hear. | |
| Vocabulary or language | If a person's vocabulary, language, or accent differs significantly from our own, we might find listening difficult | |



**Activity 3**

Listen carefully to a radio or television news bulletin of your choice. Make sure it is fresh news, (meaning that it is likely to be repeated later in the day). At the end of the news, write a summary of the news bulletin. Compare your summary with a similar news bulletin when it is repeated later in the day. To what extent is your summary a correct reflection of the news? If your summary is markedly different from the news, what could have been the barrier to communication duly to your listening session? Make a list of the challenges that you have encountered and repeat the exercise the following day to perfect you listening skills. Now, compare listening to the radio and television. What is the main difference? What more differences are you likely to encounter when you compare the two with listening to a speaker directly?

**Assessment test**

1 In your own words, explain the difference between listening and hearing.
2 Identify the five different kinds of levels of listening.
3 Identify five strategies that can improve listening.
4 Provide a brief example of a dialogue between a doctor and a patient with a cultural barrier. Provide a strategy for overcoming such a barrier.



**Summary**

Our first encounter with a verbal language is through listening. It is not surprising; therefore, that listening is the dominant communication skill. It is partly because of this factor that most people take listening for granted. Even students at all levels have a tendency of not considering listening seriously as they do with writing, for instance. Yet most of the time spent during study activities is on listening.

We must always remember that listening is a skill that can and need to be perfected through proper training. This can be done effectively by avoiding potential barriers to listening at all levels. Let the objective for each listening session guides you as regards the choice of the listening skills.



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# Unit 4 Note Taking

## Introduction

The preceding unit has talked about listening skills. You will recall that one way to enhance our understanding of messages we hear, is to put them down. At first, it may appear that this process is haphazard. You need sound organisation and mastery of some skills and techniques. This is where the process of note taking comes in.

Note taking is one of the most important skills in the life of a student. Being able to take useful notes from lectures or written materials is a critical part of your study programme. It is always important to record the essence of any presentation or write up. This unit therefore aims at giving you tips to successfully take down notes. You will also be introduced to two different types of notes.

**Areas of emphasis**

- Note taking
- Aims of note taking
- Types of notes
- Abbreviations in note making
- Semantic markers



**Key words**

- notes, abbreviations, outlining, branching, semantic markers

**Prerequisite knowledge**

As a student you have ever taken notes from either a reading material or a lecture. This experience will be quite useful in this unit.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit, you should be able to

- mention two types of notes
- distinguish two types of note taking methods
- use abbreviations when taking notes
- take notes when studying.

**Resources needed**

To understand this unit, you need to have the following materials:

- a radio, A4 paper, A pencil, an eraser, a pencil sharpener

## 4.1 Note taking

This is a process of writing brief information in a format. Sometimes this is done using symbols and abbreviations in order to write down main points and sub points of what you have heard or read.

You ought to know that note taking is one of the most important single things you can do to perform well in your study programme. Being able to take notes from oral or written texts is therefore critical to academic activities. When taking notes you must always remember that your interest is in recording the essence of ideas presented snot everything that is aired out or everything written on a topic. For this to be possible, you will need to possess some skills and techniques that can assist you to gain excellence.

## 4.11 Aims of note taking

There are a number of reasons for taking notes but following are the most relevant for you:

i) To have a record of the speaker's or writers main ideas – you are likely to come across diverse information. You therefore need to develop a selective mind so that you can be taking down only the main ideas not copying every word.
ii) Notes are memory aids. They thus help you revise previously taken notes before you take an examination and consequently pass with good grades.
iii) Note taking also enables you to make what the speaker or writer says become part of your own knowledge. You will realise that the notes are presented in our words and written in materials that we possess. We thus develop ownership and the knowledge becomes our part and parcel.

### 4.1.2 Basic requirements for successful note taking

As we have already indicated, the process of note taking is very tricky. When you are listening to a presentation, you cannot control the rate at which the speaker produces information. Worse still, it is quite often a tall order to discern between main ideas and trivia. You are therefore required to do the following:

a) Concentrate on what the speaker is saying. At this juncture, you need to be focussed. Refrain your mind from wandering and make a deliberate effort to overcome all distracters that can cripple your listening process.

b) Identify the main points. Not everything spoken or written down is noteworthy. You need to develop a critical thinking skill so that you can easily differentiate between important information and irrelevant substances.

c) Take notes quickly but in a well organised way. You will not have time to take down notes. Therefore, refrain yourself to be at writing. However, this fastness must

not make you develop notes in a disorganised manner. Always be organised because if you are not, your own notes may confuse you and this may trigger failure.

### 4.1.3 Tips for successful note taking during lectures

**A) Be prepared for the lecture**

- Read previous notes
  If the lecture is a continuation of a previous lecture, read your notes on the previous lecture to refresh your memory. This will give you a good background than can foster your understanding of the forth coming lecture.

- Ask yourself some questions
  You need to devise some questions about the coming lecture. If you know the topic of the lecture, ask yourself these questions:
  a) What do I already know about the topic?
  b) What do I expect to learn?
  c) How will the topic relate to other topics already discussed?
  d) How will this topic help me?

These questions are crucial in that they can promote a positive attitude towards the coming lecture. More importantly, they act as pace-setters in your quest for absorbing new knowledge.

**B) During the lecture**

When attending a lecture you need to conduct yourself in a manner that particularly promotes grasping of concepts. The following are desirable to enhance comprehension.

i) Sit in the front or centre of the classroom
If you sit in the back of the room or near a door or window, your concentration will suffer. You may be distracted by so many things like people playing outside, someone singing enticingly and so on. Sitting in the front or centre will also enable you clearly see materials written on the black board or presented on an overhead projector.

ii) Try not to write out the lecturer
At all cost, do not attempt to develop the habit of removing the lecturer in your thoughts. At all times, make him or her an integral part of your studies and this will promote capturing of information, being presented. Sometimes, the lecturer may say something that you strongly disagree with and you may want to stop listening; do not do this. Try to concentrate on what the presenter is saying rather than reacting to it.

**C) The actual process of note taking**

i) Listen for cues that indicate important ideas
Cues are also known as semantic markers or signalling devices. They perform different functions and some of them are:

- **To show emphasis**

In this category, we have the following examples:

- I would like to emphasise …….
- The point you must remember is …..
- It is important to note that …..
- It is worth noting that ……
- I repeat
- The next point I'm going to give is very crucial
- Listen carefully to this

Every time such phrases are uttered, you must know that an important point worth taking down is about to be raised.

Here we look at examples such as:

- Firstly - in the first place; - to begin with
- Secondly- in the second place
- Thirdly
- Lastly

- **To show illustration**

We have examples such as:

- Let me give you some examples
- For instance, for example ….
- Let's take ….
- An example of this is …..
- To illustrate this point …….

You should jot down examples given in a lecture. Reasons for doing this is two fold:

a) Examples increase your understanding of ideas
b) They serve as a reminder of the basic ideas when you revise.

- **To show contrast**

Examples include:

- But …
- Nevertheless …
- On the other hand …
- And yet …
- Although

- **To sum up**

Semantic markers used in this category include:

- What I have been saying is this …
- If I can just sum up …

- **To rephrase**

Examples are:

- In other words …
- Let me put it this way …
- To put it in another way …
- That is to say …

- **To show digression**

Digression refers to departure from main subject in speech or writing. During a lecture, when digression occurs, it means that a presenter has side-tracked is saying not directly to the topic. You are therefore not supposed to note down digressions because they are just included in a lecture to spice it up.

- **Nonverbal clues**

Here, the focus is shifted from use of language to transmit ideas and messages. Instead, other features like facial expressions and voice emphasis are considered. You therefore need to recognise voice emphasis in sentences. Particularly check for emphasised words

or phrases; similarly, watch out for facial expressions that are used to denote a strong point. You must also closely watch gestures being made in a presentation. They two illustrate an issue of great importance.

### 4.2 Note taking and abbreviations

When taking down notes, you need to develop some strategies to enable you cope with the speed at which the speaker is presenting the information. Even when you are reading a book these strategies are equally useful. One of the most effective strategies is the use of abbreviations. You are encouraged to use standard symbols and abbreviations.

#### 4.2.1 Reasons for using abbreviations

a) To keep up with the speaker
b) To make the task of note-taking easier.

When using abbreviations, you need to be very clever and extremely careful by observing the following:

- Use abbreviations that you will remember when reviewing your notes sometime later. It does not help using abbreviations you are not familiar with as this can only confuse you and make your study session very ineffective.
- Make abbreviations clear so that they will not be mistaken for other words.

#### 4.2.2 Types of abbreviations

You may come across several types of abbreviations, but here, we will only talk about three kinds of abbreviations:

- **Field Abbreviations**

These are abbreviations used in different fields. For example, the following are used in Chemistry: C, Ca, Na, H2O.

- **Commonly understood abbreviations**

This category refers to symbols commonly used in mathematics. For example:
&, =

- **Personal abbreviations**

These are abbreviations made up by an individual for personal use. Anybody can develop his/her unique abbreviations which they can use in the notes. These should be those that one understands easily and can never confuse when reading the notes. When developing them you need to:

- Abbreviate words that are frequently used in a particular lecture or in a particular book.
- Abbreviate words by leaving out vowels

Eg ppl for people
Pplr for popular
Mgt for management

Ltd for limited
Sch for school

- Abbreviate by using only the beginning of a word.

E.g.

- ad for advert
- Add for address or addition
- Hemi for hemisphere
- Reg for region or registration
- Mon for Monday

### 4.2.3 Types of notes

You need to be familiar with these two types of notes: outlining notes, and branching notes.

**a) Outlining notes**

These are notes that are made in a way that shows main points, subtopics and supporting points are shown. These are made by numbering.

In these notes, you are supposed to put the subject title/topic preferably a short one, at the top, underlined in block letters but not numbered.

Following it are numberings for the main topic, subtopic and supporting points. Here, you are at liberty to use different numerals. What matters is consistence. For example, if your first main point starts with a capital Roman numeral **I** then the second main point will be **II**. This trend has to continue till the last main point. On your sub points if they start with Arabic Numerals (i.e. **1**) or Alphabet letters in capital letters **(A)** make sure that you are consistent throughout the notes. For instance, if we start our first sub topic to be numbered **B** and the trend goes on up to the last sub point. Similarly, our supporting point is labelled **a,** the next point of the same will be **b** and so on and so forth. This trend will be repeated in the supporting points for the second main point, third point etc. You should also remember to present your notes in indented format. Thus the first sub topic supporting the main point should be indented and so should the supporting points for the sub topic. This style helps to clearly demonstrate differences on points and above all to promote neatness and good organisation of our notes.

Let us now look at how real notes can be presented using this format.

**Topic**

I First main idea of the topic
  A First subtopic supporting the first main idea
    1 Important fact under first subtopic
      a) First detail supporting **a**
        i) First Minor detail supporting **a**
        ii) Second detail supporting **a**

a) Second detail supporting **1**
b) Third detail supporting **1**

B Second subtopic supporting first main idea
1 1st important fact under second subtopic

II Second main idea of the topic
A First important fact under second subtopic
1 First important fact under second subtopic
a) First detail supporting 1
b) Second detail supporting 1

2 Second important fact under second subtopic
a) …
b) …

With this layout in mind, you need to read the extract below and see how the notes have been developed out of it.

In general, marriage ceremonies are designed to do four main things. The first is to mark the change from one family into another. It used to be a custom in Scotland, for instance, for an old shoe to be thrown after the bride when she left her home to show that her father no longer had any legal right over her.

Among many tribes, a mock fight is staged at the wedding to show the resistance of the bride's family to the carrying off of its members.

Another common function of the marriage is to protect the couple from evil influences. The veil worn by the bride in western cultures was originally designed as a barrier to evil spirits. In oriental countries, brides often wear small mirrors because it is believed that spirits are frightened away when they see their own faces. In Africa and Europe, guns or arrows are often shot in the air to kill or frighten away evil spirits that may be nearby.

A further point is that most marriage ceremonies in the world contain features designed to make sure that the marriage will produce children. In many countries in Europe and Asia, the seeds of various grains are thrown over the couple or poured in their laps. In some countries in Eastern Europe, a small boy is placed on the lap of the bride as part of the ceremony.

Finally, marriage ceremonies generally contain features stressing the unity it is hoped the couple will achieve. In Celebes, the bride and groom are sewn together by their clothes and in several countries a knot is tied to signify the joining in marriage.

Thus we can see that although the details of the marriage ceremony differ widely from culture to culture, the basic purpose, to mark a change from one family to another, banish evil, promote fertility and produce unity, are same in all peoples.
Adapted from Chimombo, M. (ed) 1999.
Note-Making: An MSCE English Language Guide pp. 35 – 36

From the above passage, we can make some notes in outlining format using the methodology that was discussed before. As already discussed, only essential parts are considered. Our notes would look as below:

## Marriage Ceremonies

I **Change of family**

A) Old shoe thrown after bride
- Scotland

B) Mock fight at wedding
- In many tribes

II **Protection from evil spirits**

A) Bride wearing mirror
- Oriental countries

B) Bride wearing mirror
- Oriental countries

C) Guns & arrows shot in the air
-Africa & Europe

III **Promoting fertility**

A) Throwing grains
-Asia

B) Small boy placed on bride's lap
-Eastern Europe

IV **Unity**

A) Bride and groom sewn together in clothes
- Celebes

B) Knot tied

That is how the passage on marriage ceremonies could be transformed into notes based on outlining format.

 **Activity 1**

Read the passage below and outline notes using the traditional number /letter format.

**Musical instruments**

There are many different kinds of musical instruments. They are divided into three main classes according to the way that they are played. For example, some instruments are played by blowing air into them. These are called **wind** instruments. In some of these, the air is made to vibrate inside a wooden tube, and these are said to be of the **woodwind** family. Examples of woodwind instruments are the flute, the clarinet and the bassoon. Other instruments are made of **brass**: the trumpet and the horn for example. There are also various other wind instruments such as the mouth-organ and the bag pipes.

Some instruments are played by banging or striking them. One obvious example is the drum, of which there are various kinds. Instruments like these are called **percussion** instruments.

The last big group of musical instruments is of those which have strings. These are of two main kinds: those in which the music is made by plucking the strings and those where the player draws a bow across the strings. Examples of the former are the harp and the guitar. Examples of the later are the violin and the cells.

 **Activity 2**

Listen to any radio programme that lasts for a minimum of thirty minutes and develop an outline of what has been presented.

**b) Branching notes**

These are notes that are developed by means of circles and lines connected as branches to show relationships between concepts or points.

Branching notes are useful in the absence of an outline lecture. They are very flexible to develop and you can easily recapture the speaker's original message and see the relationships between ideas more clearly.

i) **Developing branching notes**

To take branching notes begin by stating your subject or topic in a few words at the centre of a blank sheet of paper. Then as you absorb some ideas and details either from a lecture or a book, put them in boxes or circles around the subject and draw lines to connect them to each and to the topic. Put minor ideas or details in smaller boxes and use connecting lines to show how they relate as well.

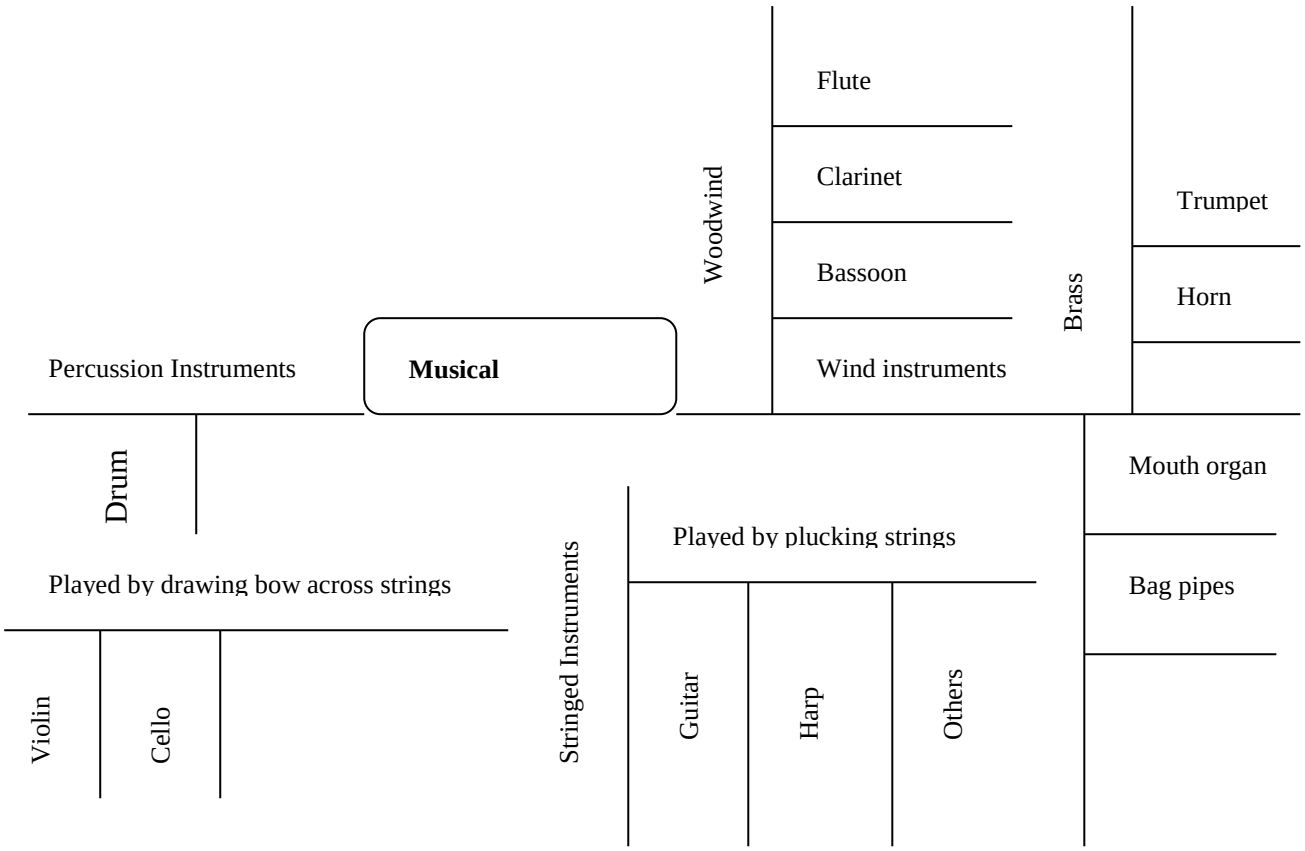
ii) **Tips about branching notes**

1 Have a double-page spread of note paper.

2 Take notes only on one page of the double pages. Use the other page for adding more information of 'reconstituting' notes, i.e. rewriting your notes in fuller or more convenient form. Keep in mind that there is no right or wrong was of branching your notes. What is important is to demonstrate that various ideas and details relate to one another.
3 Make a habit of noting the lecturer's name, the subject and date of the lecture.
4 This is very useful in instances where you may have questions since you can easily contact the lecturer concerned.
5 Always remember to put the topic of the lecturer in the centre of the page. If the central topic is not clear, use the first topic.
6 Relate other topics to your central topic and one another by using lines.

**An illustration of branching notes**

We have already seen how the passage on musical instruments can be developed into outlining notes. At this point, let us use the same passage to make branching notes. In doing this, we should be mindful of what has been discussed above. Carefully made, our notes would look as follows:





**Activity 3**

Carefully read the passage about Mzuzu University and transform it into branching notes.

**Mzuzu University**

Mzuzu University opened its doors in 1999. It started with one faculty which was and is still called Faculty of Education.

The Faculty of Education consists of among others; Department of Languages & Literature, Education and Teaching Studies Department, Mathematics Department and Basic Sciences Department. In addition, in around 2003 a new faculty called Faculty of Environmental Sciences was established. This faculty has in the meantime two departments; Forestry and Land Management.

In 2008, a new baby was born. This is called the Faculty of Information and Communication Technology. Currently there are two departments within it namely; Library Information Science and Information and Communication Technology.

More importantly, the Faculty of Health Sciences has just been created at Mzuzu University. For a starter, the Department of Nursing has set the ball rolling but many more departments are in the pipeline. It is expected that by the year 2010, there shall be more faculties with a variety of departments collaborating to achieve the goal of educating Malawians.



**Activity 4**

Present the passage on 'Marriage ceremonies' in branching notes form



**Self assessment test**

1 State three advantages of using outlining notes over branching notes.
2 Why is it important to take note of linking words during lectures
   a) Why are abbreviations important in note taking?
   b) Name any two types of abbreviations.



**Summary**

In this unit, we have looked at the skill of note taking. You will recall that we have explained all steps that are involved when taking notes. We have stressed the importance of using abbreviations in note taking because they allow us to keep pace with the speaker and more importantly, we save time when our notes are taken from written materials.

We have also discussed two types of notes and each type can be used. It is our hope that from now onwards you will be able to take useful notes which can be used in your study.

The next unit will look at how your effective notes can be used in your study sessions as you prepare for examinations.



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# Unit 5 Effective Study Skills

## Introduction

After you have studied during the better part of your academic life. Sometimes you register success whereas other times you literary reap nothing out of your studying. You m ask yourself what went wrong. How can I study effectively? What are the needed skills and strategies to efficiently utilise my study time? The list may be endless. It is the purpose of this unit to provide you with tips on how to study effectively. The other part will equip you with taking skills which are integrated in the study process.

**Areas of emphasis**

- reasons for studying
- planning of study time
- tips on effective studying



**Key words**

- study
- plan
- budget
- supplies

**Prerequisite knowledge**

Studying is something people do throughout their lives. As a student you have assignments to read, papers to write and tests to take. For all these to be successfully accomplished you need to spend the better part of your time studying. The experiences that you have gone through will be helpful in this unit.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:-

- define the term study
- explain the importance of studying
- describe a study plan
- budget and organise resources

**Resources needed**

For you to easily understand this unit you need to have the following materials

- dictionary, A4 paper, pencils, pens, highlighter, eraser, sharpener

### 5.1 Studying and planning

In this section, we will look at two words; studying and planning. Though distinctive, these words are interrelated and they complement each other to assist learners meet some set goals.

**Study -** there are several meanings for the word and you will likely come across a variety of meanings. Despite this, in this unit, the term study **refers to the process of spending time in learning (one or more subjects) as part of an educational course.**

Studying should be viewed as a learning process. When you are learning, your primary objective is to acquire new knowledge. Similarly, a study session must be a forum where you want to learn a new thing or you want to add on to the existing knowledge. If this goal is implanted in your mind you will enjoy your studies and you will be purposeful.

For effective studying, you need to tune yourself properly. Apparently, there is a problem when some students hear the word **study** they think of a task imposed by a lecturer. They say "that's what I have to do to get good grades or prepare for a presentation." Often, it may seem as though studying is something you do for others, not yourself but is a serious misconception. Rather, studying is a process which must stem down your mind with a primary aim of meaning something. It must originate from your quest for knowledge not as an assignment. If you have the will to study, you will get psychologically prepared and will easily overcome all barriers. Consequently, you will register success unlike when you perceive it with a negative and unprepared mind.



**Activity 1**

1 People study for different reasons. Give two reasons why you study.
2 List down some of the challenges that you face when studying
3 How can you solve the challenges listed in 2?

### 5.1.1 Reasons for studying

As you have already seen, studying is related to learning. You should conceive it as a discovery process where at the end of the day, you will accrue some new knowledge. By this token, when we are studying, our aim is to learn new concepts. At times we may be continuing with materials that have already been studied and in that case the aim is to add on the existing knowledge.

Whatever the situation, the bottom line is, studying yields something – it is a learning process. Every time you complete a study session, ask yourself a question "What have I learnt"? If you have not grasped anything from your study know that it was wasteful – not effective. So try to establish the reasons behind and ameliorate the situation in the next study session. If you do this continuously, you will realise that your studies are very effective, beneficial and rewarding to your academic life.

### 5.1.2 Planning

Planning is one of the most important things in your studies. **It refers to a carefully considered way of carrying out some activity.** In other words, it is a tool for getting

things done. A good plan brings success in whatever one does. This is so because it guides your activity – when to do what.

**A study plan**

In this section you budget your time. You carefully split your time into different activities to be completed at set times. A plan for study is based on your strengths, the time and resources you have and how your work will be evaluated. Proper planning will accord you chance to use your time productively. It will also help you work efficiently. For instance, sound planning can help you break down an assignment into manageable pieces.

### 5.1.3 Organising your study time

Here we look at how we arrange our time in order to yield successful studying. You need to carefully draw up a time table (schedule) to ensure that you have the time you need to achieve whatever you set forth for the day.

This time may cover a day, a week or even a month depending on the nature of your activities. Your plan ought to be clearly formulated – splitting your time into different tasks. When doing this, evaluate how much time you have and how you spend that time.

Before drawing a time table, track down where your time goes. Your day begins when you wake up and ends when you fall asleep. You will see that during the weekday, your time is spent on attending classes or meetings. During that time, you cannot use your time for other thins. Instead, you have some breathing spaces. These have to be planned in order for you to utilise them fully.

After classes or meetings, you will discover that your time needs to be shared in order to accomplish some activities like – studies in the library, laundry, recreation, sports, writing assignments etc. For all these to be fulfilled, you need careful planning. It is therefore important to develop a general timetable that covers academic and non academic activities. For effectiveness sake, make sure you budget your time in such a way that every activity is given ample time. Make it a point that the activities do not interfere with each other.

Look at the following example:

*Figure 5.1 General timetable*

| TIME | MON | TUE | WED | THUR | FRI | SAT | SUN |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 6 a.m. | Shower | Shower | Shower | Shower | Shower | Shower | Show er |
| 7 a.m. | breakfast | breakfa st | breakfa st | breakfast | breakfast | breakfast | Break fast |
| 8 a.m. | **C** | **C** | **C** | **C** | **C** | **L** | **C** |
| 9 a.m. | **L** | **L** | **L** | **L** | **L** | **A** | **H** |
| 10 a.m. | **A** | **A** | **A** | **A** | **A** | **U** | **U** |

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 11 a.m. | **S** | **S** | **S** | **S** | **S** | **N** | **R** |
| 12 Noon | **S** | **S** | **S** | **S** | **S** | **D** | **C** |
| 1 p.m. | Lunch | Lunch | Lunch | Lunch | Lunch | Lunch | Lunch |
| 2 p.m. | **C** | **C** | **C** | **C** | Class | Watching TV | Watching TV |
| 3 p.m. | **L** | **L** | **L** | **L** | Class | Watching TV | Watching TV |
| 4 p.m. | **A** | **A** | **A** | **A** | Sports | Watching TV | Watching TV |
| 5 p.m. | **S** | **S** | **S** | **S** | Sports | Watching TV | Watching TV |
| 6 p.m. | Supper | Supper | Supper | Supper | Supper | Supper | Supper |
| 7 p.m. | Library | Library | Library | Library | Library | Watching TV | **S** |
| 8 p.m. | Library | Library | Library | Library | Library | Watching TV | **T** |
| 9 p.m. | Library | Library | Library | Library | Library | Watching TV | **U** |
| 10 p.m. | Library | Library | Library | Library | Library | Watching TV | **D** |
| 11 p.m. | **S** | **S** | Chatting | **S** | Watching TV | Watching TV | **Y** |
| 12 Midnight | **L** | **L** | Chatting | **L** | **S** | **S** | **S** |
| 1 a.m. | **E** | **E** | **S** | **E** | **L** | **L** | **L** |
| 2 a.m. | **E** | **E** | **L** | **E** | **E** | **E** | **E** |
| 3 a.m. | **P** | **P** | **E** | **P** | **E** | **E** | **E** |
| 4 a.m. | **I** | **I** | **E** | **I** | **P** | **P** | **P** |
| 5 a.m | **N** | **N** | Jogging | **N** | Gym | Jogging | Jogging |

In summary, a careful budget will accord you time to study, play and do whatever you want with your time. It must be emphasised though that a particular consideration should be given to recreational activities. Remember, "all work and no play makes Jack a dull boy". We think you do not wish to be dull so take some time off the books and

explore on other things. You will discover that it is an enriching experience befitting a student.

 **Activity 2**

Use the figure below to develop a general time table for yourself.

| TIME | MON | TUE | WED | THUR | FRI | SAT | SUN |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 6 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 7 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 8 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 9 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 10 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 11 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 12 Noon | | | | | | | |
| 1 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 2 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 3 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 4 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 5 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 6 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 7 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 8 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 9 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 10 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 11 p.m. | | | | | | | |
| 12 Midnight | | | | | | | |
| 1 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 2 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 3 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 4 a.m. | | | | | | | |
| 5 a.m | | | | | | | |

### 5.1.4 Tips for effective studying

In the previous section we have seen the importance of planning. Much as it is that fundamental, you ought to know that there are also some tips which are equally important.

Before we discuss these tips, we have to emphasise that studying is a process that is supposed to result in learning. Sometimes, however, it does not. You may be putting in long hours poring over your text books yet earning only average grades or even failing altogether. Sometimes you may be getting excellent grades after of hard work and exhaustion.

That does not mean you are unable to learn. Rather, it means you need to plan for effective study. You need to know strategies that can put you in control of your studies and consequently your learning.

The following tips/strategies will help you when studying:

**Linking previous knowledge to new information**

You need to properly link what is already in your brain to new information. This can be achieved by asking yourself questions such as:

- What do I already know about this?
- How does what I am reading match with what I know already? Does it make it clear?
- does it shed light on ideas I was unsure of?
- do I need to replace incorrect details with new ones?

Answering these questions will give you an impetus to benefit from your study and to foster your learning process effectively.

**Organising thoughts and time**

You equally need to organise your thoughts and time. Again a set of questions will aid you to accomplish this:

- What do I want to do?
- How do I reach my goal?
- Of the choices I have, which one is best in this situation?
- How much time do I have?

These questions act as pace-setters and if you give them correct answers, you will be able to benefit from any study session that you have.

**Channelling energy to the task**

Another fundamental thing achieving study is to dedicate your energy to the task at hand. Have a deliberate mechanism to see off all barriers that would deter your concentration. You will find the following questions useful for this task:-

a) Do I monitor internal distraction, such as hunger, fatigue and emotional highs and lows?
b) What about external distractions, such as noise, lighting and supplies?
c) What question or questions am I asking and answering at the end of the study session?

**Conduct studies in the library**

a) Libraries are havens as far as studying is concerned. They are designed to encourage studying; therefore, they have a lot to offer students. They are quiet, well lighted and comfortable.

b) When you are at the library, you will not be interrupted by visitors or distractions by family members laughing at a television show.

c) You will not only have large tables or desks on which to spread out your papers, but you will also have many more resources to choose from. Besides books, you have access to periodicals, newspapers, computers for internet etc.

d) They have assistance who help you find materials, direct your searches, tell you what services the library provides, and look up information for you.

 **Activity 3**

When you are studying at home, what are some of the problems that you face. List as many as you can.

**Develop study habits**

Studying may be a hassle often times. If you do not have the right attributes towards it you may always be futile. It is important to develop habits that can assist you cultivate interest in your studies. The more good study habits you have, the more enjoyable your studies become and the more you understand materials. At first it may be difficult to develop positive habits and attitudes towards studying but the following activity will help you overcome this difficulty.

 **Activity 4**

The following statements aim at measuring your study habits. As you read the statements, indicate how true each statement is for you by marking **'Never', 'Seldom', 'Sometimes', 'Often'** or **'Always'**.

The inventory below contains pertinent statements that can foster your studies. You need to answer them correctly and that will be helpful in your day to day studies

**Inventory of Study Habits**

**1 2 3 4 5**

**When I Study Never, Seldom, Sometimes, Often, Always**

1 I try to judge how the writer's ideas make sense.
2 I try hard to remember details, such as names, dates, and technical, terminologies.
3 I can't focus on what I read for long periods of time.
4 I connect what I am reading to ideas learned in other classes.
5 I take time to copy my notes before I study them.
6 I find it hard to keep my mind on my work.
7 I try to understand what I read so that I could say it in my own words
8 I reread materials that I already understand.
9 I tend to day dream.
10 I think of ways to apply what I learn.
11 I go over what I read page by page in order to remember the details.
12 I need time to get "warmed up" to the task.
13 I relate what I read to real-life experiences.
14 I take extensive notes on what I 'm reading.
15 I am likely to waste time getting started.
16 I find what I read for class meaningful to me.
17 I find my study periods are interrupted by noise, visitors or telephone calls.
18 I try to memorise word for word most of the information have been assigned to read.

### 5.1.5 Managing study resources

By the study resources, we refer to materials you need to effectively conduct your studying. You may also need the following:- lined paper, typing paper, note books, graph papers, filing folders, calculator, stapling machine, staple remover, highlighters, pens, pencils, erasers, rulers, scissors, tape, glue, dictionary, disks, hole punch, atlas, calendar and thesaurus.

The materials in question need to be properly managed. You can achieve this by:

- Having a filing system for your papers
- Many papers will come your way every day from your own notes on lectures or reading and from handouts lectures give you
- To keep these safely you need to have a chip folder or three ring binder file in which you file your loose papers reading and file your papers according to their subjects
- You also need to punch holes in the papers for secure filling.
- You should also use labelled dividers to separate the various subjects in your folder/binder.
- File your papers by date. This gives you a clear record of classes and how your studies are progressing.



**Self assessment test**

1 Write brief note on the following terms:
   - studying
   - planning
   - budgeting
   - study supplies
2 Why is proper time management crucial in the process of studying?
3 Amongst the study tips discussed in this unit, which ones do you prefer most? Give reasons for your choice.



**Summary**

In this unit, we have tackled two important issues to a student. The fist part has dealt with studying. As has been explained, studying is very important a process. It has been seen that success in academic tasks mainly derives from effective studying. To underscore this, tips and strategies to register success every time one is studying have been enumerated. You have been given reasons for studying. It is therefore important to consider studying as a very crucial thing and develop a liking for it.



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# Unit 6 Reading Skills

## Introduction

The primary goal of this unit is to enable you to identify and acquire some specific skills that will make you to become both an efficient and effective reader. We shall define reading and look at the process of reading and reading initiative. We shall also explore the reading strategies of scanning, skimming, inferencing and prediction when reading. Later, we shall teach you how to identify the structure of discourse in reading text and, how to read critically.

**Areas of emphasis**

- definition of reading
- process of reading
- efficiency in reading
- reading strategies
- critical reading



**Key words**

- dynamic, sensation, perception, comprehension, reaction,
- conceptual abilities, process strategies initiative, scanning,
- Skimming, prediction, inference, discourse, signification
- functional value, rhetorical structure

**Prerequisite knowledge**

As a student your daily life revolves around reading. This experience will help you to understand the contents of this unit.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:-

- define reading
- describe the reading process
- describe efficient
- describe reading initiative
- use the skills of prediction, scanning, skimming and inferencing effectively when reading
- identify the structure of discourse in a reading text and
- read critically.

**Resources needed**

The following materials would help you enhance your understanding of this unit:

- a piece of paper, telephone directory, timetable, notices, letters
- instructional leaflets, label of medicine bottle

## 6.1 Definition of reading

You engage in many reading activities in your daily life. Take five minutes to list all the different kinds of things you have read recently. Do not forget to include things like telephone directory, timetable, notices, letters, instruction leaflets and label of medicine bottle.

Different people have different views of reading. This is because different people use the word to mean different activities. So let us start by making sure that we are thinking about the same thing when we use the term reading. Will you therefore please take a piece of paper and write down briefly what happens when you read.

Your answers are likely to have used words like:

- understand, interpret, meaning, sense, etc
- decode, decipher, identify, etc
- articulate, speak, pronounce, etc.

Reading may involve all these activities. The basic objective of reading is to get the meaning of the text one reads. In other words one reads in order to understand what the text communicates to him or her. To do this, the readers bring their backgrounds; their experience, as well as their emotions into play. A reader who is upset or physically ill will bring these feelings into the act of reading and the feelings will influence the way he or she interprets the text. A person who is very good at reading will understand more than someone less knowledgeable. A reader who is a good critical thinker will gain more from a critical passage than one who is not. A reader who has strong dislikes will come away with different feelings and understandings from those of a reader with strong likes.

 **Activity 1**

Now, in your own words define the term reading.

**Definition of reading**

A broad definition which can be used is that reading is a dynamic, complex act that involves the bringing to and the getting of meaning from the printed material

### 6.1.1 The process of reading

As you read silently, these notes, what are you doing? If you are a good reader and are attending carefully to what the notes are trying to say, you will notice the following:

**a) Sensation**

First, what are your eyes doing? They move together in a swift and well coordinated way. As they move they make a series of alternating pauses or fixations and quick, jerky, side-wise movements. The eyes see the printed symbols only when motionless during pauses or fixations. This is the first step in the process of reading. It is called sensation. Sensation is awareness that there is something on the printed page.

**b) Perception**

Sensation is followed by perception. Perception is interpretation of what has been sensed. When a pattern in symbols reaches the brain it is compared with the memory traces of similar patterns. A person usually has many experiences that help him or her to form a concept of a word. Such experiences could be of taste, feel, colour, size and weight. He or she also learns to associate the verbal label of a word with this collection of meanings called concept and traces representing both the concept and its verbal label stored in his or her memory. This combination of seeing and recognising meanings is called perception.

**c) Comprehension**

To understand what the writer communicates, involves a series of perceptions taking place in rapid succession. It means recognising symbols as printed word and perceiving it as well as perceiving the word when it is part of a sequence of words used by a writer to express an idea. The reader has to re-create the author's intended meaning. In order to comprehend as text one has to use one's knowledge of **syntax** and **semantics** to extract meaning from a series of perceptions of words.

**d) Reaction**

When we read we react physically, intellectually, as well as emotionally. For example, in Section 4.7 the definition of reading given, we asked you to take five minutes to list the different kinds of things you read recently. You physically stopped reading these notes to perform this activity.

Sometimes when you read a story, you come to a section where a hero of the story is threatened and your pulse may be quickened or some apprehension may arise. At other times you may read an article and accept, reject or criticise it. This means you are involved emotionally.

### 6.1.2 Efficient reading

Do you usually understand what you read? It is important that you should be able to read well and competently or efficiently. Efficient reading depends on the interaction of three factors. These are conceptual abilities, background knowledge and, process strategies. Let us look at each one of these in turn.

a) Conceptual abilities are one's intellectual capacity to analyse, synthesise and make inferences or guesses from material. To synthesise means to put things together to come up with a meaning.

b) Background knowledge is one's previous knowledge of the social and cultural aspects of the setting and content or what one already knows about the topic.

c) Process strategies, on the other hand, are abilities and skills needed to reconstruct the meaning of a text based on the knowledge of the sentence structure, of the language, vocabulary and so on.

### 6.1.3 Initiative in reading

Initiative is personal capacity for thinking up and beginning action; that is to say, the habit of starting and finishing a job because you know about it.

The following are habits that show initiative as a reader:

- trying to make sense of what one is reading,
- connecting new ideas to ideas that one already knows and,
- putting things in one's on words.

Such habits have two things in common. They show that the reader is in active control of what he or she is reading; that is, that the reader is not a passive receiver of ideas. And secondly, they show that the reader cares about what he or she is doing.

If you adopt such habits, you will find that whatever you are reading will be more interesting, easier to understand and easier to remember.

**How to take initiative in your reading**

**a) Before you begin reading**

- Think about the title of what you are going to read. Ask yourself what you already know about the topic.

- Read any questions or summaries at the end of the sections or chapters. These indicate the main points to look for in what you are going to read.

- Notice whether the passage is divided into sections indicated by subheadings. If so, attack the reading material section by section instead of thinking of it as a whole. The sections are like the chewable bites of food.
- Examine all pictures, graphs and maps so that they should be easy to refer to when they are mentioned in the passage.

**b) As you read**

- From time to time stop and put into your own words what you have just read. In other words, say to yourself what you have read as you understand it

- Frequently stop and ask yourself whether your reading is going well: whether you really understand what you are reading
- Link the ideas you are learning about in the passage to everyday examples that illustrate them. Make conscious effort to judge how the ideas you are studying make sense

- Take rough notes as you read. This is one way of putting the ideas or information in your own words

**c) After you read**

- Close the book and try to remember the ideas you have just read in the passage.
- If there are questions at the end of the passage, try to answer them without looking at the passage.
- Examine how much you have learnt. Ask yourself how your understanding has changed.

 **Activity 2**

Apply the hints you have just read on how to take initiative in your reading in reading the rest of the notes in this unit and check how your understanding will be improved.

## 6.2 Reading strategies/ techniques

### 6.2.1 Scanning

You often look up numbers in a telephone directory and words in a dictionary. How do you read when you do this? As a matter of fact, what you do is you scan for information. By scanning, we mean glancing rapidly through a text either to search for a specific piece of information (such as a name or date) or to get an initial impression of whether the text is suitable for a given purpose (such as whether a book on farming deals with the cultivation of a particular crop). Scanning can also enable you to find the main idea of a text or a required detail. Your scanning rates will vary according to the text, your purposes and your comprehension abilities.

- Information in content textbooks varies in the way it is organised. It follows one of the following four formats:
- Information is divided into units (sections), chapters, major headings under chapters, minor headings under major headings. This is called categorical format.
- Alphabetical format. This is when glossaries, bibliographies and indexes as well as some types of charts are arranged alphabetically.
- Historical format: when sequential information is arranged chronologically or in time format.
- Sometimes on the basis of its importance, information is arranged from least to most important or from most important to least important. This is hierarchical format.
- Determining the format of the presentation of information is the first step in scanning a text.

**Clues for scanning**

Begin scanning by making purpose setting questions and answers indicating main ideas you look for, for example:

| *If your question begins* | *Quickly look for* |
|---|---|
| When? | Capitalised words like days, months or time periods, time of day, years, words like before, during, after, soon, later, prior etc. |

Where? Capitalised place names and words like behind, across, near, next to etc.
Who? Capitalised words of names of groups, nouns.
Why? Words like because, for that reason, consequently, as a result etc.
How? A sequence or words such as by, through, as result of, etc.

In summary the following are the steps you can follow to scan the main ideas in a text:

- Determine the organizational format of the information.
- Estimate the type of response a purpose setting question requires.
- Search for clues which point to the answer.
- Verify the answer by slowing down and reading around the answer.

**Skimming**

Sometimes when you buy a newspaper, you glance rapidly through an article to determine its gist or its general overall idea. This is called skimming. Just like scanning, some words in a text may be ignored or skipped as you read the article. Another example of skimming is when we glance rapidly through a research paper in order to decide whether the paper is relevant to our own work (not just to determine its field, which can be found out by scanning), or in order to keep ourselves generally informed about matters that are not of great importance to us.

The difficulty of the text and your familiarity with the topic determines how quickly you can skim. Your speed will increase when you focus on nouns, verbs or key words and phrases and transfer these to working memory. You should also selectively ignore adjectives, adverbs and connectives; that is to say, prepositions and conjunctions. Further, you should review typographical aids, such as, bold face and italics as well as graphics like charts, maps and graphs. This will ensure that you include key points of a chapter.

Skimming can be used to preview a chapter and getting the gist of a chapter.

**A) Steps in skimming**

Here are the steps that you can follow in order to skim a chapter effectively:

- Read the title (think of the information the chapter could contain and what you already know about the topic).
- Read the list of objectives at the beginning of a chapter (if any) and predict what you should be able to do at the end of the chapter.
- Some texts list terms with specialised meanings at the beginning of a chapter.
- Look at meanings in context.
- Skim the introduction or first paragraph. The first sentence or paragraph usually states the main idea of each section or chapter.
- Read the boldface headings. These identify the topic of each section.
- Look accompanying graphs, charts etc. Visuals emphasise main points and summarise details.
- Note typographical aids. When they are written in the body of a text, they highlight important new terms. In margins, they outline important facts.

- Read the last paragraph or summary of the chapter. These often restate the main ideas or conclusion.

**B) Making predictions about content**

The idea that the best way to begin reading a chapter is to make predictions about what each section contains and that this helps you interact more actively with the text will seem strange to you. Instead of just reading, look for specific information.

You can make predictions about a chapter by:

- Examining chapter objectives provided by the author which can help you set learning goals and determine if you have met them.
- Previewing the chapter summary or review questions – these will help you identify important information be learned from the chapter.

### 6.2.3 Inferencing

Have you noticed that sometimes as you follow the writer's trend of thought from one utterance (sentence) to another, you find that you cannot see the connection between the two utterances? When this happens, it means the writer is expecting you to draw inferences (from other things he/she has said) to bridge the gap. When you use the information collected in a text to come to a conclusion about additional facts and information that are not specifically started, you are drawing logical inferences. For example, what can a reader infer from these two sentences?

"The treatment was later withdrawn."
"The next day the patient died."

The reader is can infer that the death was caused by the withdrawal of treatment.

 **Activity 3**

Read the following text and then read the facts stated below. Tick all the facts that you think are implied by the text:

> One of the Archaeopteryx specimens was at first wrongly catalogued as a small pterodactyl, because its feathers were very difficult to discern. This shows how even the experts considered it a reptile.
>
> This implies that:
>
> - Archaeopteryx is a reptile.
> - Pterodactyls do not have feathers.
> - Pterodactyls are reptiles.
> - Pterodactyls are large compared with Archaeopteryx.
> - Archaeopteryx has feathers.

### 6.3 The structure of discourse in a reading text

Writers organise their information in paragraphs and these are in turn organised in a variety of ways. For instance, the organisation of the test could be done according to logical progression of ideas from general to specific or, from specific to general.
Sometimes, the structure could be that of cause-results, according to sequence of events described or, the structure could be that of problem – solution. This last structure can be illustrated in the following text from Chesterman (1962, p. 208):

"Diseases of the eye are common in hot countries and some of these are very infectious. Handkerchiefs, towels and pillows are common ways in which germs go from a bad eye of one person to the good eye of someone else. Persons suffering from eye trouble often want to rub their eyes with their fingers and handkerchiefs. Anyone suffering from a sore eye should wash his hands after touching it. His towels, handkerchiefs and pillow should be kept apart from other people and all cotton wool and rags used to wash the eyes should afterwards be burned."

A paragraph is like an essay in miniature. Thus these examples of structures can apply to complete texts such as stories, ayes and articles. Organisation of narrative material (for example) could begin with a situation which sets a problem, followed by a series of events revolving around the problem which eventually leads to a climax in action or resolution of the problem. In the same way an essay or article could begin with an outline of problems, followed by a description of the problem and/or a text could begin with an introduction of a topic, followed by discussion on the topic or aspects of the topic and/or examples and conclude with a summary of the main points discussed.

It is therefore possible to give a general description of the organisation of most paragraphs or texts as follows:-

| **Stage** | ***What takes place*** |
|---|---|
| **Beginning** | *Setting the situation*<br>*or*<br>*introduction of topic or main argument* |
| **Middle** | *discussion of topic*<br>*explanation of topic*<br>*description of problems or aspects of topic and/or*<br>*giving of examples* |
| ***End*** | *result*<br>*solution to problem*<br>*summing-up*<br>*re-emphasis of argument*<br>*generalisation on topic* |

**Activity 4**

Get a copy of a newspaper. Turn to the page where there are letters to the editor. Describe the organisational structure of the letters on this page.

## 6.4 Signification and value

The broad and general structure of a text, however, does not tell us much about what happens in the text. To understand what happens in the text, we need to see how a writer combines sentences to convey the message or to form stretches of discourse.

There are two types of meaning of an utterance or sentence. The first is **signification,** ie. the meaning that an utterance can have on its own even if it is not used in a context. The second is **value,** the meaning or significance of an utterance in a particular context or the reason why an utterance is said.

If we take the utterance, for example:

*'Farm animals can be divided up according to the number of offspring they have'*

We can think of different contexts where the sentence could have value: as an **explanation** why farm animals are different; as a **reason** why farm animals have different characteristics; as a **conclusion** of the discussion on differences between farm animals and so on. The value of an utterance or sentence can only be understood when it is used in a certain context.

In a text, a writer usually writes a number of sentences, each with its own communicative value. And the sentences acquire their values from what has been said before or after it. To illustrate this, let us analyse the values of sentences in the following text. We have numbered the sentences in the text:

1 The ability to write well organised, concise paragraphs is essential to a student's success in almost all university courses.

2 In preparing scientific reports of laboratory experiments, a student must present his findings in a logical order and clear language in order to receive a favourable evaluation of his work.

3 To write successful answers to essay questions on history or anthropology examinations, a student must arrange the relevant facts and opinions according to some acceptable pattern of paragraph structure.

4 When a student writes a book report for English, or a critique for political studies, or a term paper for sociology, style and organisation are often as important as content.

5 Clearly, skill in expository writing is crucial to successful achievement in most university subjects.

This text may be analysed as follows:
Sentence 1 is **asserting;** sentences 2, 3 and 4 are **exemplifying** the assertion made in sentence 1, and sentence 5 is **concluding** or **re-emphasising** the assertion in sentence 1.

This complex network of relationships within a text is its rhetorical structure. It is the structure of the underlying ideas, and connections the writer makes between them. Its elements are rhetorical acts that sentences perform; that is to say, their functional values.

Now read the following text and the structure of discourse in the text.

**Malnutrition**

The struggle against malnutrition and hunger is as old as man himself, and never across the face of our planet has the outcome been more in doubt. Malnourishment afflicts an estimated 400 million to 1.5 billion of the world's poor. Even in the affluent U.S., poverty means under-nourishment for an estimated ten to twenty million. Hardest hit are children, whose growing bodies demand two and half tomes more protein, pound for pound, than those of adults. Nutrition experts estimate that 70 percent of the children in low-income countries are affected.

**Misshapen** bodies tell the tragic story of malnutrition. Medical science identifies two major types of malnutrition which usually occur in combination. The first, kwashiorkor, is typified by the bloated look, the opposite of what we associate with starvation. Accumulated fluids pushing against wasted muscles account for the plumpness of hands, feet, belly and face. Emaciated shoulders reveal striking thinness. Caused by an acute lack of protein, kwashiorkor (a West African word) can bring brain damage, anaemia, diarrhoea, irritability, apathy and loss of appetite.

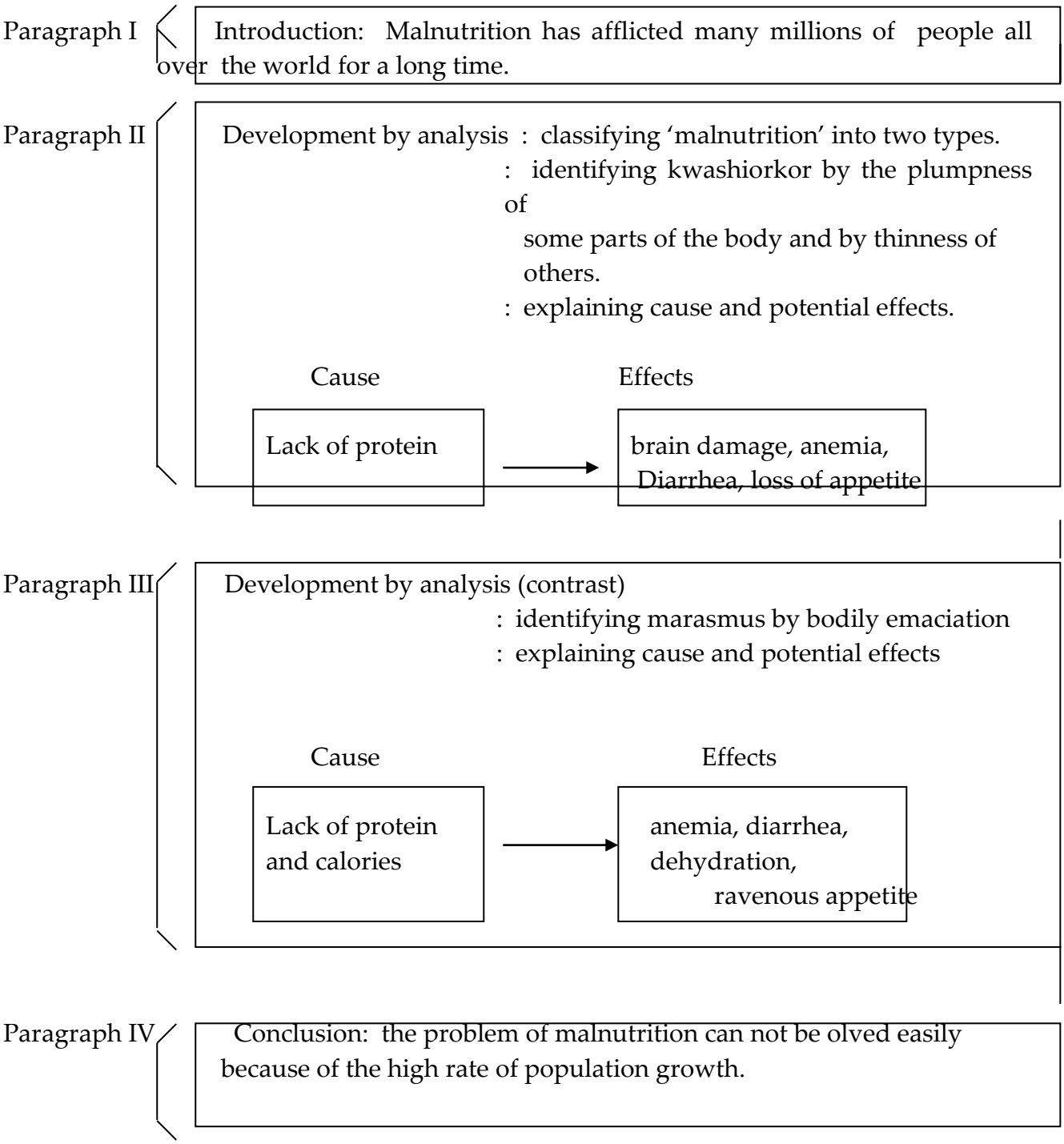
On the other hand, stick limbs, a bloated belly, wide eyes, and the stretched-skin-face of an old person mark victims of marasmus, a word taken from the Greek "to waste away". Lacking carolies as well proteins, sufferers may weigh only half as much as normal. With fat gone, the skin hangs in wrinkles or draws tight over bones. With marasmus comes anaemia, diarrhoea, dehydration, and a ravenous appetite. Children, whose growing bodies require large amounts of protein, are afflicted in greatest numbers, but perhaps only three percent of all child victims suffer the extreme stages described.

Scientists are working feverishly to develop new weapons against malnutrition and starvation.

But two thirds of the human population of 3.9 billion live in the poorest countries which also have the highest rates. Thus, of the 74 million people added to the population each year, four out of five will be born in a have-not

country – a country unable to supply its people's nutritional needs. (from Foundation Reading II, Vol 3 by the Chalulangkorn University Language Institute)

**Look at the organization of the whole passage**




So there are three parts in the passage:

- The introduction
- Development (by analysis, classifying the two types, then contrasting them by explaining the cause and effect of each);

- The conclusion

**Critical reading**

Critical reading is the reading that you partake so that you can judge the value of what you read. This skill enables you to determine whether you should accept or reject the ideas in a text or seek additional information.

Sometimes students think that because a statement is written in a text book or journal article, it is automatically a fact. This is not always true. To be an efficient reader, you need to know if what you read is an opinion, a fact, or a fact and an opinion combined. Most of the study material you read are writer's opinions or combinations of opinion and statements of fact. You should distinguish between these.

### 6.5.1 Distinguishing between fact and opinion

Consider the following statements and say which states a fact or an opinion:

a) Cats are more loving than dogs
b) Malawi receives 50 millimetres of rain yearly
c) My friend Akuzike Banda is a resident of Lunzu, Blantyre
d) Fishing relaxes you better than sleeping

In the above sentences, (a) and (d) are opinions while sentences (b) and (c) are facts.

A fact is anything that can be proved or validated. If a statement can be proved right or wrong by verifiable testing or measurement, it is a fact. An opinion cannot be validated. If no right or wrong can be established, the statement is an opinion.

 **Activity 5**

Say which of the following statements are facts and which are opinions:

a) My uncle died in 2001.
b) The temperature in the oven is 35 degrees Celsius.
c) Potatoes are better when eaten hot.
d) It is sunny outside.
e) Johannesburg is the best city to visit in South Africa.

Some statements may include both facts and opinions. Consider the following:

a) The Jaguar XJS has a twelve-cylinder engine and is the most beautiful car made.
b) She is having a fifteenth birthday on January 28 and will be emotionally upset.

In sentence (a) you can verify that the Jaguar XJS has a twelve-cylinder engine but that it is the most beautiful car made is an unverifiable opinion. Similarly, in sentence (b) it can be proved that January 28 is her birthday but that she will be emotionally upset may be difficult to validate.



**Activity 6**

Some of the statements below state facts, some express opinions, and others may include both facts and opinions. Identify statements of fact, of opinion and those with both fact and opinion:

1 The only good reason to go to college is to learn.
2 Many universities provide condoms on campus, but they are morally wrong to do so.
3 Hitchhiking is a frequent method of travelling for college students.
4 My daughter once secretly kept a kitten hidden in her bedroom for nearly three weeks.
5 A tune-up will cost you K500 at the corner garage and will make your car run better.
6 The best way to eat cold chicken is to dip it in tomato source.



**Self assessment**

1 What is the reading process?
2 Briefly describe each of the following reading skills:
    a) scanning
    b) skimming
    c) making predictions
    d) inferencing

3 How does interpretation of coherence in a text aid comprehension?



**Summary**

In this unit, we have looked at the definition of reading. We have noted that reading is a dynamic and complex act that involves the bringing to and the getting of meaning from a printed page. We have also learned about the process of reading, efficient reading and initiative in reading. Various skills that are employed in efficient reading have been explained. These are prediction, scanning, skimming, inferencing and how to identify the structure of discourse in a reading text. Finally, we have discussed how you can judge the value of what you read by reading critically.



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# Unit 7 Effective examination skills

## Introduction

This unit introduces you to the necessary skills for examinations. The focus is on the proper use of examination assets; application of examination telepathy and the use of study methods.

**Area of emphasis**

- examination skills
- examination assets
- examination rubrics
- examination preparations
- examination telepathy
- effective study skills



**Key words**

- examination, assets, examination telepathy, examination
- rubrics, Clues, personal attitudes, self-esteem, self-control
- determination

**Prerequisite knowledge**

Your ability to perform well on examinations is not only dependent on your intelligence but also appropriate application of your examination skills. It is thus not uncommon for intelligent students to perform poorly during examinations due to inadequate preparations resulting from lack of examination skills. Considering that examinations constitute a very important study component as a tool to measure the extent that learning has taken place and consequently levels of performance, it is imperative to develop appropriate skills.



**Learning outcomes**

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- effectively prepare for examinations
- write examinations effectively
- develop appropriate examination telepathy
- make use of examination telepathy.

**Resources needed**

- examination past paper, study guide, notes taken during lectures

## 7.1 Background Information

### 7.1.1 Examination as a measure of performance

Preparing and sitting for an examination is often taken for granted. Rarely do students think of a need to deliberately and systematically develop examination skills. This is surprising considering that students' performance and certification are largely dependent on examinations. Study efforts of many years can easily be put to waste following a poor examination performance.

When faced with examinations, the natural tendency has been to resort to the use of our study aids which include notes, handouts, quizzes, past tests and examination papers. The challenge, however, is how to make good use of such materials.

**Examination assets**

Examination assets refer to study aids and personal skills. Study aids include all materials you keep and file away for future reference. It is thus important to develop a habit of keeping in one place all the study work papers connected with each course you take. Such materials are likely to contain exercises, tests, quizzes, reports, lecture notes, group exercises, handouts, etc. These assets are very useful when exams are approaching. You are likely to feel relaxed and at ease when you are sure of relevant materials for your study. You can easily avoid examination phobia in this way.



**Activity 1**

1 Make an exhaustive list of all examination assets in your possession. Do you have the habit of keeping such material for future use? Which other material should you keep as examination assets? Do you find such material useful?
2 Develop a filling system of your examination assets convenient to you. Can you easily refer to the material you want or does it take you a long time to do so? Improve your system as appropriate as possible.

**7.3 Personal skills** refer to the necessary skills associated with preparations as well as what candidates are required to perform when examinations are in progress.

### 7.3.1 Note taking

It is important that you continue perfecting your note taking skills. This can only be done through frequent practice in note taking. Remember that clear and well organised notes are a good study aid. They are easy to read as future reference for your study. As such, they keep you on the right track of your subject. Your notes are a record of the ideas that were emphasised in reference books as well as during lecture times and are issues that are likely to come in exams.

### 7.3.2 Understanding examination rubrics

It is important that you answer examination questions according to what the question directs you to do.

**Activity 2**
Consider the following question:

***Analyse*** *the MSCE results of 2005 and* ***compare*** *them with those of 2004, with focus on girls' performance in government secondary schools.*

1 What is this question asking you to do?
2 How many parts does the question have?

Note that the two words appearing in bold letters are the key instruction words in the sense that they instruct you on what to do. However, recognising the functions of the two words is not sufficient to enable you answer the question adequately. Now read the phrase *"with focus on girls' performance in government secondary schools."*

### 7.3.3 Key instructions special

What this phrase does is to set a **condition** to the key instructions. Due to the functions performed by such phrases, they are referred to as special **conditions**. In other words, key instruction words instruct you **conditions** on **what** to do, whereas special conditions tell you **how** to carry out the instruction(s). Other key instructions ask you to define, explain, state, name, mention, why, how, compare, contrast, differentiate, etc. Likewise, other special conditions are: briefly, fully, in detail, with examples, illustrate, etc.

Understanding the requirements of a question is the necessary skill in understanding components of examination questions. Other examination rubrics include; number of questions to answer, number of things to choose and; how many parts a question has.

### 7.3.4 Review what you learn in class or read on a daily basis

The habit of constantly reviewing what you learn in class or read in recommended books, will give you the feeling of being constantly ready for exams. It gives you a chance to correct errors and fill gaps in your knowledge.

### 7.3.5 Explain to a colleague what you have learned

The practice of explaining what you have learned to a friend does not only help in building self confidence but also helps in reinforcing you knowledge on specific aspects of your study topics. In fact a friends question on your explanation could alert you to aspects of what you have learned but you do
not clearly understand.

**Write some questions and answers** on what you have learned. This will help you remember better what you have covered in your reading or in class.

## 7.4 Personal attitudes

### 7.4.1 Develop right attitudes

Developing the right attitudes for examinations is a very challenging effort. It requires patience and a deliberate effort to resist negative **attitudes** that may negatively affect ones examination performance.

There are three major kinds of attitudes that a student needs to develop:

### 7.4.2 Curiosity

**Curiosity** refers to eagerness to learn, know or find out. It is an important attitude to adopt because it motivates you to study and is likely to result you in learning something from your studying. It thus becomes easy to remember what you learn during examination. Remember that "the quality that marks a successful learner is the desire to learn something. It's important to make whatever information you are earning meaningful. Ask yourself questions to pick your curiosity." This approach will help you see learning as more than something confined to books. It makes learning mean something in your everyday life.

### 7.4.3 Enthusiasm

**Enthusiasm:** It is important to develop a feeling of interest in exams. Of course, it is not easy but it can be done.

You should train yourself to look at a test as an opportunity to demonstrate what you know rather than looking at them as a threat. It is hard to take an interest in test if you see them as tiresome events that make you lose sleep and disturb your free time. Enthusiasm is possible only if you are well prepared for the exams.

### 7.4.4 Confidence

**Confidence:** You must build a belief that you are able to pass an approaching exam. You should not think of a possibility of failing or having to sit for a supplementary exam. It should only be a question of "how well will I pass this exam?"

Confidence is a result of determination. Determination gives you strength to overcome problems that might stand in the way of your successes. It also helps you to focus on the material relevant to your work.



**Activity 3**

In your own words, explain what you understand by the terms: *curiosity, enthusiasm* and *confidence.*

## 7.5 Examination telepathy

### 7.5.1 Telepathy

Examination telepathy refers to ability to be aware of the ideas or thoughts of another person without them telling you. In other words, it is possible to predict questions your lecturer is likely to ask in an approaching exam.

### 7.5.2 Listen for clues

Take note of the idea or points that are emphasised by your lecturer or in your reference books. It is, therefore, important to take note of semantic markers used by your lecturer or writers, such as:

- I would like to emphasise …
- The point you must remember is …
- It is important to note that …
- It is worthy noting that …
- The next point I'm going to give you is very crucial …
- Listen carefully to this …

### 7.5.3 Lecturer's use of visual aids

When a lecturer spends a lot of time using visual aids to make a point or explain a principle that is a sign he or she believes it is important. An exam is likely to come from such a topic.

**What fascinates your lecturer:** Sometimes, it is possible to tell sometimes that a particular idea or point fascinates your lecturer or a writer. You can almost guarantee there will be an exam question on that point. Previous quizzes, tests and exercises can also give you an idea of what fascinates your lecturer.

### 7.5.4 Course objectives

Course objectives are very important in determining what should appear in examinations. Exam questions are normally used to establish whether the course objectives have been achieved.



**Activity 4**

1 Briefly list factors that can assist you to predict what is likely to appear in your exam or a test.
2 List objectives for each of the courses that you take? Have you been able to meet some of these objectives in the course of your study? If not, state what needs to be done.

### Study methods

It is important to revisit the study skills you learned in unit two. Remember to start your studying early. Long term, well planned study will help you avoid cramming i.e. overstuffing your brain at the last minute close to the exams.

### 7.6.1 Avoid cramming

Note that although cramming may give enough knowledge to get some answers right, that knowledge is superficial. In other words, it is not deep enough and as such only good for the exam at hand and not for future application. Hence it amounts to short-term learning. What is required is long-term learning which is essential for genuine learning since it demands more time and commitment.

Also cramming is exhaustive because it is done at the last minute. As such, it is a hard and un enjoyable task. It is recommended to have small doses than long, last minute cram marathons. Remember that cramming takes over your life just before exams and wears you out. Well planned, strategic study will help you avoid cramming.

**Memorising**

No matter how you memorise something, what is important is to understand the meaning of what you are learning.

For instance, it is not enough just to memorise names of the bones in your body, but also you need to know how they function together.

**Use of a textbook:** It is important to read assigned pages in your textbook. Use paragraph headings to outline the material you are reading. Other features to look for are chapter titles, summaries, chapter questions, glossaries, topic sentences, materials printed in boldface or in italics and illustrations such as maps, graphs, charts and diagrams. Textbooks can also provide you with practice tests similar to what you have in this module booklet.

**7.6.3 Group study:** Use the study group only to discuss and expand on topics you are already familiar with. The objective should be to meet so as to refine each other's knowledge and not to teach each other. So make sure that the group consists of members who are all knowledgeable. You should not have a group with members who expect to be taught. Stick to a particular point of study. In other words, avoid digressing into material that is irrelevant to a particular point you have agreed to study. And prevent the study session from turning into a party.

**Examination time**

**On the eve of the examination, you are advised to do the following:**

- Get enough sleep. Do not stay up late cramming during the exam period. A sleep-starved mind will not be alert enough to enable you to do well in exams. Hence the importance of steady, long term and daily study
- Never skip any meal, especially breakfast. An empty stomach during an exam will distract you from concentrating on your work. It might also add to your anxiety about the exam;
- Avoid overeating. An overstuffed stomach can make you sleepy or sluggish, i.e. slow in thinking. Eat moderately before an exam.

- Make time for relaxation. Since your brain will be working hard for you during exam period, you must allow it to rest just as you need to rest your muscles after hard physical work
- In case of sickness, seek medical help. Never push yourself hard so that you even ignore your sickness simply because of exams.
- However, find out if the medicine prescribed might have the side effect of making you drowsy or might in some way interfere with your thinking.
- If necessary, alternative treatment may have to be prescribed.



**Activity 5**

1 Make an exhaustive list of what you did in readiness for your last examination. Can you now take note of variations with what you have covered in this unit?
2 To what extent was your previous approach to planning for exams helpful?

## 7.8 During the examination itself

a) Gather the necessary examination supplies that you need. You may use, items such as pencil, pens with enough ink, calculator, mathematical instrument box, etc. Some examinations allow the use of a limited number of reference books. In this case be sure to bring into the exam room only the necessary and permitted materials for the exam at hand
b) It is important that you arrive at the exam venue on time. Avoid arriving too early; otherwise you will be tempted to go into last-minute study with friends. This may confuse or make you unnecessarily nervous, especially when your friends disagree with you. At this time, there is no possibility of checking who is right and this can shake your self-confidence. Likewise, arriving late can be very disturbing. You will have to spend valuable time catching your breath and getting organised. And you are likely to miss crucial exam instructions from the invigilators.
c) Listen carefully to invigilator's and examiner's instructions. It is, therefore, important that you start only after getting all the instructions right, otherwise you may overlook something important.
d) Understand exam Rubrics; You may thoroughly know the material but you may miss marks if you misunderstand the requirements of the question (see 5.7.1).
e) Pay attention to highlighted words (in bold type) in general exam direction.
f) Be alert for key instruction words and special conditions set for each question. Thus you must look out for words such as mention, list, state, explain, briefly, define, describe, compare, discuss, etc.
g) Never ask your neighbour any question, even if you want to borrow something. It may give an impression that you are cheating. It also disturbs your neighbour. If in need of anything, ask through your invigilator.
h) Before you begin to answer any question, skim through the entire exam. This will help you see which ones are the most important questions in terms of distribution of marks. In this way you will find it easy to budget your time. In other words, you are likely to

begin with easiest questions on which you will spend less time. As you go along, this approach will help you warm up and gain confidence.

i) If a question stimulates a lot of ideas in you, quickly write them down on rough paper. Later on you may form these ideas into sentences. This ensures that no useful ideas will be forgotten as you write your answer.

j) It is important to be neat and accurate. Therefore, you need to write legibly. If your handwriting is difficult to read, your examiner may misunderstand your answer and you will not earn the marks you deserve. Poor organisation of ideas creates a bad impression. Similarly, wrong spelling and improper punctuation which may change the meaning of a sentence altogether.



**Self assessment**

1 Write brief notes on the following terms
2 Examination telepathy
3 Examination rubrics
4 Cramming
5 Why is memorising not a recommended study method?
6 Why is it important to arrive on time during examinations?
7 What does the word examine mean to you?



**Unit summary**

Examinations and tests are part of the learning process and a necessary important tool in checking whether learning is taking place or not. As such it is important that you keep on developing appropriate examination skills.

Preparation for exams cannot be confined to the last days leading to the exams' dates. It must be an on-going activity to minimise pressure characterised with "study rush" typical of the last days leading to exams.

It is equally important that you develop positive attitudes conducive to facilitating effective preparedness for examinations. Positive attitudes must be supplemented with the skills to enable you to predict areas of focus for exams questions. Such examination telepathy skills will enable you to be well focussed in your preparations and thereby sharpen your study skills.



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## Module test

1 The head of communication section insists that when students give an oral presentation they should also submit a written copy of the presentation. Give four reasons for this recommendation? **(8 marks)**

2 In preparation for her end of semester communication examinations Chiletso found a quiet secluded place for her study. This was an ideal place for her study, as she likes reading where there is total silence. But after 20 minutes of study she complained that she could not understand what she was reading because there was noise around her.

**a)** Give any two examples of the noise that might have disturbed Chiletso. **(2 marks)**

**b)** Chiletso is part of the communication process that is taking place at this secluded place. Identify the source, the message, and channel in this communication process**.(6 marks)**

**c)** Name any two disadvantages of the communication Chiletso is involved in. **(4 marks)**

3 Read the following passage and make branching notes. (**15 marks)**

**The hazards of movie going**

I am a movie fanatic. My friends count on me to know movie trivia and to remember every big Oscar awarded since I was in secondary school. My friends, though, have stopped asking me if I want to go out to the movies. While I love movies as much as ever, the inconvenience of going out, the temptations of the theatre, and the behaviour of some patrons are reasons for me to wait and rent the video.

To begin with, I just do not enjoy the general hassle of the evening. Since small local movie theatres are a thing of the past, I have to drive for fifteen minutes to get to the nearest multiplex. The parking lot is shared with several restaurants and a supermarket, so it's always jammed. I have to drive around at a snail's pace until I spot another driver backing out. Then it's time to stand in an endless line, with the constant threat that tickets for the show I want will sell out. If we do get tickets, the theatre will be so crowded that I won't be able to sit with my friends, or we'll have to sit in a front row gaping up at a giant screen. I have to shell out a ridiculous amount of money- up to $8 – for a ticket. That entitles me to sit while my shoes seal themselves to a sticky floor coated with spilled soda, bubblegum, and crushed raisinets.

Second, the theatre offers tempting snacks that I really don't need. Like most of us, I have to battle an expanding waistline. At home I do pretty well by simply not buying stuff that is bad for me. I can make do with snacks like celery and

carrot sticks because there is no ice cream in the freezer. Going to the theatre, however, is like spending my evening in a Seven-Eleven that's been equipped with a movie screen and comfortable seats. As I try to persuade myself to just have a diet Coke, the smell of fresh popcorn dripping with butter soon overcomes me. Chocolate bars the size of small automobiles seem to jump into my hands. I risk pulling out my fillings as I chew enormous mouthfuls of Milk Duds. By the time I leave the theatre, I feel disgusted with myself.

Many of the other patrons are even more of a problem than the concession stand. Little kids race up and down the aisle, usually in giggling packs. Teenagers try to impress their friends by talking back to the screen, whistling, and making what they consider to be hilarious noises. Adults act as if they were at home in their own living room. They comment loudly on the ages of the stars and reveal plot twists that are supposed to be a secret until the film's end. And people of all ages create distractions. They crinkle candy wrappers, stick gum on their seats, and drop popcorn tubs or cups of crushed ice and sodas on the floor. They also cough and burp, squirm endlessly in their seats.

4 'Personal skills are valuable examination assets'. Briefly explain this statement with reference to any three of the skills that you have learned in this course. (6 marks)

5 In what way is developing empathy a valuable component in listening? (3 marks)

**6** Imagine that you were part of the audience in the University Hall where a young lady from Youth Society was making a presentation on 'How to live a pure life'. In her presentation, the lady was tensed up and was visibly shivering with fear. Her articulation of words and the flow of sentences were very jerky. Describe how this state of affairs would affect your listening. **(6 marks)**

## Answers to unit activities

### Unit 1 Activity 1

a) The roles taken are: when you are speaking to the doctor you are the source and when he is listening to you he is the receiver. However, the roles can shift in that when the doctor is seeking clarification of how you are feeling he assumes the role of the source and you become the receiver

b) The message is about your sickness

### Activity 2

1 In a classroom setting the components of communication are:

- The source is the teacher
- The receivers are the learners
- The message is the content being delivered
- The channel is words transmitted through air and chalkboard
- The noise would be anything that may distract the communication process i.e. learners talking or a car passing nearby

2 The source of noise could be learners making noise while the lesson is in progress or noise that is coming from external sources such as people singing outside or a car passing nearby.

3 The theory does consider feedback which is very crucial in the communication process.

### Activity 3

Answers have been provided immediately after this activity. You just have to master them.

### Activity 4

1 It is oral communication because:
2 It has immediate feedback
3 It uses paralinguistic features which enhance the communication process
4 Misunderstandings and differences can be dealt with on spot
5 The setting in which communication takes place makes it very easy for messages to be received effectively
6 It is written communication.
7 These are:
   a) It has permanent records
   b) People usually understand better what they see in writing
   c) Messages can be read at the convenience of the recipient

### Activity 5

i) There is no single answer for this question.

ii) It is difficult to judge people based on their dressing and grooming because dressing can be deceptive and worse still there is no specific dressing for a specific type of people. As a result judgement that may be made on the basis of dressing and grooming would be driven by some stereotypes. For example, some girls who wear miniskirts or trousers are stereotyped as prostitutes

**Self assessment test**

1 source is the message originator
b) receiver is the intended destination of the message
c) message is the content of any communication activity
d) channel is the means by which messages move from the source to the receiver
e) medium is another name for channel and it also refers to the means by which messages move from the source to the receiver.

2 Because it at this stage where we are able to know whether the communication process has been effective or not.

3 *Comparisons*

a) Both involve sending and receiving of messages
b) Both involve an interaction of all elements of communication

*Contrasts*

a) In oral communication feedback is immediate whereas in written communication feedback is slow
b) Oral communication can be affected by an individual's mood while in written communication this is not the case. Messages can be read at the convenience of the receiver
c) Oral communication uses paralanguage to complement words but this is not possible with written communication.
d) In written communication speakers are able to organise their thoughts properly but this is not very easy in oral communication as speakers do not have ample time for that.

4 a) A theory refers to a set of ideas or statements that attempt to offer explanation as to why things happen the way they do but have never been proved.
b) In accordance with the mathematical theory of communication, the process classroom communication would require the source of the message who is the teacher and the pupils would be receivers. The message would be the content being delivered and the air through which sound waves travel plus the chalkboard would be the channel. Noise in the classroom communication would come from the pupils themselves or some external sources like cars passing nearby and children playing outside the classroom.

**Unit 2 Activity 1**

1 A number of definitions can be given but they should all reflect the fact that a library is a room where books and other materials are kept for people to borrow.

2 These resources include; newspapers, books, magazines, encyclopaedias, photocopiers, computers etc.

**Activity 2**

1 Some of the reasons for going to the library are:
- The library contains many reference materials
- The library is usually quiet
- The library has library assistants who are helpful when conducting research
- Libraries have large tables where your books and any materials that you are reading can be spread on.
- Libraries are generally well lighted as a result they good places for studying

2 These are:
- Academic libraries such as Mzuzu University Library
- Public libraries such as National Library in Mzuzu
- School libraries such as Katoto Secondary School Library
- Government libraries such as National Archives

**Activity 3**

1 These are Dewey Classification System and Library of Congress classification system.
2 The main difference is that Dewey Classification System uses numbers whereas Library of Congress classification system uses alphabet letters.

**Activity 4**

1 There are number of procedures you would follow. One of them would involve you go to the OPAC computer and initiate your search. This can be done by punching key words into the computer which will in turn display to you all materials that are available for the subject you are interested in.
2 In the library materials are arranged in a systematic and organized way following some classification schemes.
3 A Monitor is a screen that shows information on a computer.
   a) A Keyboard refers to the set of keys for operating a computer.
   b) A Mouse refers to a small device that is moved by hand across a surface to control the movement of the cursor on a computer screen.
   c) Hardware refers to the machinery and electronic parts of a computer system.
   d) Software refers to programmes that are used to a computer.
   e) Internet refers to an international computer network connecting other networks and computers.

**Self assessment**

1 Mzuzu University library is an example of academic libraries.
2 a) A computer is an electronic machine that can store, organise and find information, do calculations and control other machines.
   b) It can be used in searching information i.e. internet, it can be used for sending and receiving assignments, it can also be used for typing assignments.

3 It is because on its own, the computer cannot do anything. It needs a human being to programme it.

4 a) Library catalogue is a list of books and other materials found in the library.

b) It is important because it avoids time wastage since one easily knows materials found in the library without taking the trouble of checking in the shelves.

5 Libraries are important because:

- The library contains many reference materials
- The library is usually quiet
- The library has library assistants who are helpful when conducting research
- Libraries have large tables where your books and any materials that you are reading can be spread on.
- Libraries are generally well lighted as a result they good places for studying

**Unit 3 Activity 1**

The nonverbal cue used are:

- shaking hands which denotes exchanging greetings
- throwing arms sideways which denotes showing despair

**Activity 2**

| **Barrier** | **Explanation/example** | **Solutions to overcome barrier** |
|---|---|---|
| Competing noises | Our hearing can be obscured by noise such as shuffling feet in a class, clashing cafeteria trays, other conversations | Discipline the noisy learners and talk loudly to offset external noise |
| Blocked view | Someone could sit between the speaker and listener. The sitting arrangement might not allow easy viewing of the speaker | Sit where you can see properly |
| Poor speaking volume | A speaker who doesn't "speak up" creates a barrier for listeners | Tell the speaker to raise his or her voice |
| Listener's physical condition | We sometimes try to listen when we are tired or ill. | Take a rest and resume listening when you are fully refreshed |
| Listener's attitude | Sometimes a listener is not prepared to listen to someone. The listener can be bored or prejudiced, sometimes even hostile. The listener might even be listening selectively; that is, the listener might be listening to only things he or she wants to hear. | Avoid prejudiced mind when listening |
| Vocabulary or language | If a person's vocabulary, language, or accent differs significantly from our own, we might experience listening difficult | Use language and accent that is appropriate for your audience |

**Activity 3**

The challenges may vary from individual to individual as such you are supposed to list down the challenges you have faced and how you intend to address them.

**Self assessment**

1 Listening is an active process of receiving, constructing meaning from and responding to the spoken and/or nonverbal message while hearing is the passive process of receiving sounds

2 These are:

- listening for pleasure and enjoyment
- listening for information
- critical listening
- precision listening
- empathic listening

3 These are:

- use language that is appropriate for your audience
- speak in a manner that is audible enough
- fuse your presentation with some activities such as jokes, questions etc
- have a mind that is prepared to listen
- be in a room that is conducive for listening and avoid noisy environments
- have a sober listening mind and avoid being influenced by our attitudes

4 This depends on the example that you come up with.

**Unit 4 Activity 1**

The outline should look as below:

**Musical instruments**

1 Wind instruments

Played by blowing air into them:

A Woodwind instruments- air made to vibrate into the wooden tube

1) lute
2) larinet
3) assoon

B Brass instruments- made of brass

1) trumpet
2) horn

C Others

1) mouth organ
2) bagpipes

II Percussions

Instruments played by banging/striking them

eg. drum

III Stringed instruments (have strings)

A Played by plucking strings

1) harp

2) guitar

B Played by drawing bow across strings

1) violin

2) cello

**Activity 2**

Answers will depend on the subject of the programme you listened to. However, it is important that you adhere to all features inherent in outlining notes.

**Activity 3**

You have to use circles and lines to show ideas which are related. Main ideas should be enclosed in large circles or boxes and supporting points should be in smaller circles or boxes than the ones used for main ideas. You should also remember to put the heading of the passage in the biggest circle and it has to be put on the centre.

**Activity 4**

There is no single diagram that can be illustrated here. However, you should emulate the example that has been given on branching notes. What is crucial though, is for you to show how the heading, main ideas and supporting points are related to each other.

**Self assessment**

1 Advantages of using outlining as opposed to branching notes:

- they are simple to make
- they do not require a double sheet of paper
- they do not call for reconstitution (rewriting) of the notes later
- they are not time consuming

2 Linking words will help you to identify important points in a lecture hence you will be able to take down only those points that matter not stuff like digressions or jokes.

3 a) Abbreviations are important because:

- they help you to keep up with the speaker
- they make the task of note taking easier

b) These are:

- Field abbreviations
- Commonly understood abbreviations
- Personal abbreviations

**Unit 5 Activity 1**

1 There are so many reasons for studying. Some of them are:

- To learn thoroughly what has been taught in class

- To revise and remind yourself about what was taught in class
- To discover new knowledge

2 The challenges faced are:
- Difficult vocabulary
- Temptations to fall asleep
- Failure to concentrate due to noise

3 Solutions
- Have a dictionary
- Use a conducive study environment that cannot lure you into sleeping
- Choose places that are not affected by noise

**Activity 2**

There is no single answer for this question. You just have to develop a timetable that is properly balanced. This implies that your general time table should accommodate both academic and extra-curricular activities

**Activity 3**

Problems faced when studying at home may include:
- Lack of internet to search for additional information
- Lack of library assistants to help with the task of searching for information
- Noise from people
- Lack of adequate reference materials
- Temptations to join relatives who are listening to the radio or watching television

**Activity 4**

No single answer is expected here. You have to give answers that correspond well with your study habits.

**Self assessment**

1 a) Study refers to the process of spending time in learning one or more subjects as part of an educational course that is done intrinsically not because someone is forcing you.
b) Planning refers to a carefully considered way of carrying out some activity
c)Budget refers to plan of how you are going to spend your time
d) Study supplies are materials that you need to effectively conduct your studying

2 It is crucial because sound time management will enable you to accomplish all tasks that you plan for various times of the day.

3 This question depends on individual taste and reasons for justification will depend on the nature of response given

## Unit 6 Answers to selected activities

### Activity 1
Your answer should indicate that reading is a dynamic and complex activity that results in getting meaning from the printed page.

### Activity 3
iv

### Activity 5
Sentence 1 is **asserting**, sentence 2 is **exemplifying**, sentence 3 **describing** and sentences 4 and 5 are **advising.**

### Activity 6
a) Fact
b) Fact
c) Opinion
d) Fact
e) Opinion

### Activity 7
a) Opinion
b) Fact and Opinion
c) Fact
d) Fact
e) Fact and Opinion
f) Opinion

### Self assessment
1 It is a series of actions through which a reader goes through when reading. These stages are

a) Sensation or awareness that there is something on the printed page; b) interpretation or cognition of what has been sensed, (c) understanding what the writer communicates and

b) Reacting physically, emotionally or intellectually to what one reads.

2a) Glancing rapidly through a text either to search for a specific piece of information (such as date) or to get an initial impression of whether the text is suitable or not for a given purpose.

b) Glancing rapidly through a text, such as a newspaper article, to determine its gist or its general overall idea.

c) Making predictions about what a text or each section of a text will contain before you read the text.

d) Using the information collected in text to come to a conclusion about additional information that are not specifically stated in the text.

3 Each sentence in a text has its own communicative value. The sentences acquire their values from what has been said before or after. Since writers present information which relates in particular patterns to produce a coherent text, interpreting coherence helps the reader to understand the structure of a text as well as the message or information in the text.

**Unit 7 Activity 1**

1 These assets include notes, books, handouts, pamphlets etc.
2 The filling system should certainly assist you in finding information that you are looking for.

**Activity 2**

1 The question asks you to analyse the MSCE results of 2005 and to compare them with those of 2004. However, the focus should be on performance of girls in government secondary schools.
2 There are two parts.

**Activity 3**

1 Meaning for words:

- Curiosity refers to the strong desire to know about something
- Confidence implies the belief that one is able to do something
- Enthusiasm refers to a strong feeling of excitement and interest in something and a desire to be involved in it

2 There is no single answer for this question. You are at liberty to mention all personal attitudes that you feel are relevant for preparation of examinations.

**Activity 4**

1 These factors are:

- Listening for clues- watch for ideas or points that are emphasised by your lecturer
- Lecturer's use of visual aids- watch when a lecturer spends a lot of time using visual aids to explain a point, it indicates the importance of the point being discussed
- Take note of what fascinates your lecture.
- Course objectives- sometimes lectures ask questions to test whether the course objectives have been met or not.

2 No definite answer for this question. Your respond is dependent on the course objectives and whether they have been met or not.

**Activity 5**

1 A variety of lists can be generated here.
2 Certainly this unit has given you wonderful tips and you will realise that your previous approach was not as effective as it will be after acquiring the examination skills contained in this unit.

**Self assessment**

1a) Examination telepathy refers to the ability of the candidate to predict questions that will be asked in an examination.

b) Examination rubrics refer to words of instruction and direction that guide a candidate on what should be done in an exam.

c) Cramming is the study method where a candidate learns a lot of things at a short time in preparation for an exam.

2 Memorising is not recommended because it leads to short term learning which may not be helpful at the end of the day.

3 It is important because you do not have time to enter into last time discussions which may be confusing nor do you panic to catch up because the exam starts when you have already arrived and you also do not miss instructions from the invigilator.

4 The word examine refers to a process that tests the knowledge of learners from things they have learnt.

**Module assessment test answers**

1 These are:

- written communication provides permanent records
- written communication can be read at the convenience of the recipient
- people generally understand what they see in print
- messages in written communication are well structured therefore they are easy to understand because they are likely to have better grammar and sentence structure
- written communication can reach distant places, which means it is easier to share this information with students from other universities

2 a) These may be emotional or psychological noise and verbal noise. For instance, psychological worries about coming exams and difficult words in the text which made understanding difficult.

b) Source – book

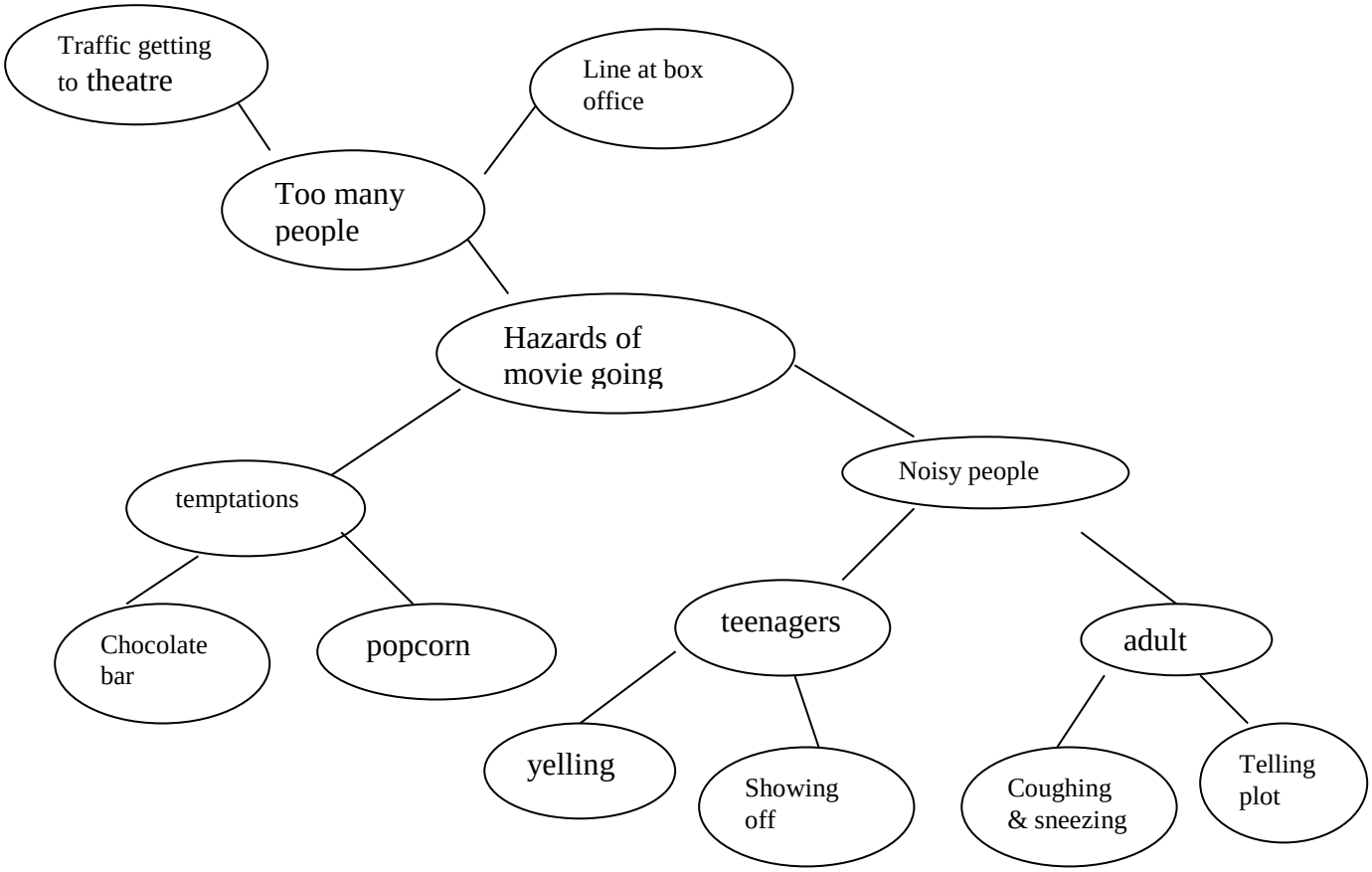
Message - content of the book

Channel – print

c) These disadvantages are:

- Chiletso cannot ask the source for clarification
- There are no nonverbal cues to help Chiletso get the message
- Language errors may make the message vague or altogether make communication impossible

2 The branching notes would look as follows:




4i) Note-taking skills are important because they enable a student to learn correct and revise quickly and effectively for examinations

ii) Reviewing notes on daily basis- this is important because during the semester, a student should develop a habit of reviewing what is learned each day by going back to the notes. This process allows him/her to make corrections where necessary and reflect on what has been taught thereby deepening understanding

iii) Understanding the examination rubrics- it is important for a candidate to fully understand instructions and directions in an exam. This is critical because it enables the candidate to know what he or she is asked.

5 It is important because it enables you to be in the shoes of the speaker. This act leads you to a concrete understanding of the message. In fact, you try to understand the message exactly the way the person feels.

6 Firstly, her lack of confidence might have made you as a listener to doubt the validity or authenticity of the message.

Secondly, it acts as a distracter to listening in the sense that instead of concentrating on the message, the audience "shut off" and just resort to watching the shivering or shaking. Some enjoy it while others feel pity and may start avoiding looking at the speaker thereby missing para-language.

Thirdly, the shivering or jerking affects the articulation of words or sounds which in turn makes reception difficult. Consequently, interpretation becomes problematic. The confusion of the sounds, tone, mood and pitch or voice inflexion has a bearing on interpretation of speech.



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